
Shunting Inhibition and Dendritic Branching Shape Local Credit Assignment

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Abstract

Biological neurons assign credit across branching dendrites, where synaptic drive, dendritic conductance, local voltage, and somatic teaching signals interact to shape synaptic plasticity. We study conductance-based dendritic networks with E/I synapse banks, shunting inhibition, and tree-structured branch-to-soma coupling, and examine when restricted somatic feedback can approximate compartment-specific backpropagated errors. Exact gradients factor into *local eligibility* $\times$ *compartment error* terms: the eligibility uses presynaptic activity, driving force, and input resistance, whereas the fast non-local term is a path-specific error obtained by transporting a soma error through dendritic gains. This factorization turns local learning into a credit-signal compression problem. We test the hypothesis that shunting inhibition benefits learning under these constraints when it reshapes the compartment-error field to better match global scalar, per-soma, low-rank, or path-structured feedback. Exact-gradient reconstruction verifies the factorization; path-gain, rank, broadcast-fidelity, inhibition-intervention, and transported-error-oracle diagnostics support the proposed mechanism. Under nonnegative conductances and per-soma 5-factor (5F) feedback, shunting LocalCA remains 5–6 percentage points below matched backpropagation on MNIST, Fashion-MNIST, and figure-ground MNIST, indicating that feedback-field fidelity remains a major bottleneck. These results show how E/I conductance, shunting inhibition, and dendritic branching can reshape credit-signal geometry in restricted local learning.

1 Introduction

Unlike point units in standard neural networks, biological neurons assign credit to synapses distributed across branching dendritic trees. Each synapse receives presynaptic drive and samples local membrane voltage, synaptic reversal potential, and total conductance, whose reciprocal is the local input resistance. Inhibitory synapses increase total local conductance, counteracting local excitation while shunting voltage to alter the gain of every dendritic path passing through that compartment.

We examine whether these biophysical ingredients can facilitate local credit assignment (LocalCA). Exact backpropagation [16] assigns a distinct error to every dendritic compartment, whereas a biologically plausible supervisory signal is more likely to arrive as a low-bandwidth somatic or modulatory broadcast [21]. The central question is therefore not whether such a broadcast can reproduce unconstrained backpropagation in every setting, but when the exact dendritic error field is simple enough to be approximated by a low-bandwidth broadcast. Our contribution is not simply to add dendritic structure to a neural network, but to show how conductance-based synapses, shunting inhibition, and dendritic topology determine the geometry of the credit signal.

Starting from conductance-based dendritic voltage equations [1], we derive exact gradients for dendritic trees (Fig. 1; Theorem 1). Each synaptic gradient factorizes into a synapse-local eligibility

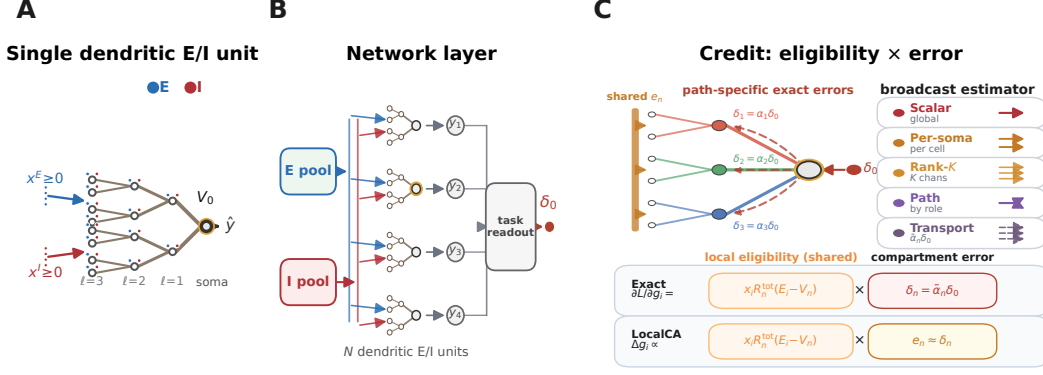


Figure 1: **Model and credit assignment.** (A) Dendritic E/I unit with branch synapse banks. (B) Layer of such units projecting to a task readout; $\delta_0 = \partial L / \partial V_0$ is the soma/core error used for feedback. (C) Exact updates multiply local eligibility by path-specific errors $\delta_{u,n}$; LocalCA replaces them with broadcast estimates $e_{u,n}$ of increasing fidelity.

term and a single non-local compartment error:

$$\text{gradient} = \underbrace{\text{local eligibility}}_{\text{presynaptic drive, } E - V, R^{\text{tot}}} \times \underbrace{\text{compartment error}}_{\text{path-specific non-local term}}.$$

The compartment error is path-specific: under identity upward transfer it is the corresponding soma error multiplied by a conductance-stage path gain through that dendritic tree. LocalCA preserves the exact local eligibility and replaces this path-specific error with a broadcast field.

What is local in LocalCA? The fast eligibility variables are synapse- or compartment-local: presynaptic drive, local voltage, driving force, and input resistance. We call the three-factor eligibility-times-error rule 3F, and use 4F and 5F for empirical extensions that multiply the same fast eligibility by slowly estimated branch-level reliability factors. The fast task-dependent non-local quantity is the compartment error, approximated by a broadcast field e_n . Thus LocalCA variants differ by the broadcast estimator and optional branch-level modulators, while preserving the same local eligibility mechanism.

This factorization turns local credit assignment into a feedback-compatibility problem. An intrinsic low rank of the exact compartment-error matrix is useful, but is not sufficient: the error field must also align with the particular feedback object available to the rule. We therefore distinguish global scalar broadcast, neuron-wise/per-soma broadcast, random low-rank feedback, path-structured feedback, and exact transported-error oracles. Dendritic branching creates the paths; E/I synapse banks set the local conductance state; and shunting inhibition changes the input resistance along each path. Shunting is not assumed to help LocalCA monotonically. It helps restricted feedback when inhibitory conductance attenuates high-gain paths or otherwise makes the exact error field better aligned with the available broadcast.

Related work. This work builds on models of dendritic signal integration, branch-level nonlinear computation, divisive normalization, three-factor (3F) plasticity, and biologically plausible teaching signals [1, 3, 4, 8, 9, 12, 18–20, 23, 27–29, 35, 36, 46]. It also connects to machine-learning approaches that replace exact backpropagation with local, random, predictive, equilibrium, perturbation, or broadcast feedback signals [14–17, 22, 30–34, 37–41]. Our contribution is complementary: we derive the exact conductance-tree credit object and test when shunting inhibition and dendritic morphology make that object broadcast-compatible.

We test this chain directly. Exact-gradient reconstruction verifies the factorization numerically (Fig. 2). Gradient-fidelity diagnostics are used as diagnostics, not as a claim of backpropagation equivalence: shunting improves directional alignment relative to an additive control, but the absolute cosine remains modest, while scale mismatch is substantially reduced. Exact-error rank and direct broadcast-fidelity diagnostics show that shunting can make the compartment-error field easier to approximate by the feedback field used by the learning rule. Transported-error oracle experiments show that supplying the exact path-transported compartment error substantially reduces the local-learning gap. Together, these results identify feedback fidelity as an important bottleneck in these experiments.

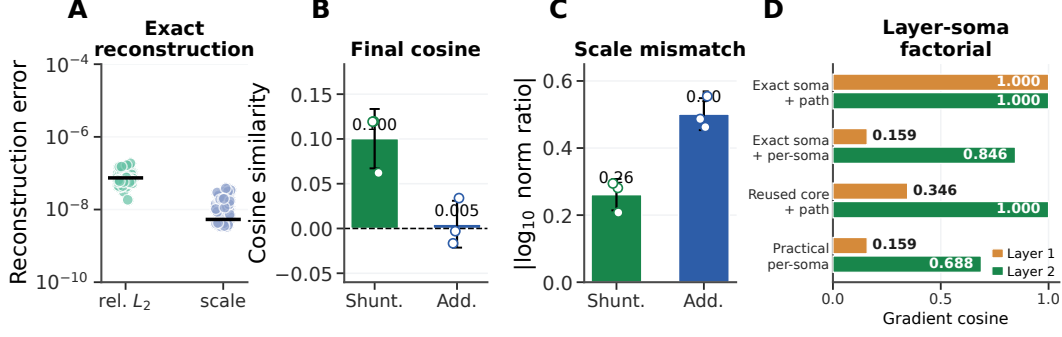


Figure 2: **Exact reconstruction and gradient diagnostics.** (A) Exact-factorization reconstruction matches autograd. (B,C) Final LocalCA-backpropagation cosine and scale mismatch; dots show seeds. (D) Layer-soma factorial diagnostic separating exact vs. reused soma teaching signals and exact path transport vs. per-soma sharing. Metrics/protocol: Appendix A. Error bars in (B,C) are ± 1 s.d.

Contributions. This paper makes three contributions. First, it derives the conductance-stage path gain, its local-eligibility and path-error factorization, and a closed-form inhibitory path-gain ratio. Second, it identifies path-gain and broadcast-compatibility metrics that mediate whether restricted somatic feedback can approximate exact compartment errors. Third, it shows empirically that shunting inhibition can improve this approximation while also identifying regimes where scalar or low-rank feedback fails.

Scope of evidence. Analytical statements concern the conductance-tree factorization, path gains, and inhibitory path-gain derivatives under the stated steady-state assumptions. Simulation controls test exact reconstruction, broadcast fidelity, transported-oracle upper bounds, and additive/shunting comparisons. Biological interpretations are restricted to branch-local inhibition and morphology-dependent credit routing; transported-error experiments are oracle diagnostics, not proposed biological learning rules.

2 Compartmental Voltage Model and Gradient Derivation

For each dendritic compartment, we use a steady-state conductance model derived from discretized passive cable dynamics [1, 2]. In normalized units, leak and inhibitory reversal potentials are set to 0, the excitatory reversal potential is set to 1, and leak conductance is fixed to 1, so all conductances are expressed relative to leak. Each compartment computes a conductance-weighted voltage: excitatory conductance pulls the voltage toward the excitatory reversal potential, leak and shunting inhibition pull it toward zero, and dendritic coupling transfers child voltages upward toward the soma. This form makes local sensitivity depend on both driving force ($E - V$) and total input resistance R^{tot} . Throughout the manuscript we write dendritic morphologies as rooted trees $[b_1, b_2, \dots, b_D]$, where each factor gives the fan-in from one dendritic stage to the next on the path to the soma. Thus, $[3, 3]$ means that each soma aggregates 3 proximal branches and each proximal branch aggregates 3 distal branches, for 9 distal leaves per soma. In the main feedforward experiments, synaptic inputs terminate on dendritic branches rather than directly on the soma. Each branch layer carries explicit excitatory conductance-based synapse banks and, when enabled, learned inhibitory branch-level conductance-based synapse banks driven by nonnegative inputs. This is input-driven shunting inhibition, not a recurrent lateral inhibitory circuit; explicit inhibitory-cell controls are reported in the appendix. The additive and shunting cores are architecture-matched at the tree level and differ only in the branch-level synaptic integration rule. These ingredients play distinct roles in the credit-assignment argument. Branching creates the path structure whereas E/I synapse banks determine the local conductance state. Shunting turns inhibitory conductance into a multiplicative change in path gain through input resistance. The local learning rule then examines whether a low-bandwidth teaching signal can substitute for the exact path-specific error induced by the dendritic tree. **Notation.** A compact reference is provided in Appendix Table S1. We use $\delta_{0,u}^{(\ell),V} = \partial L / \partial V_{0,u}^{(\ell)}$ for the exact voltage-space error of soma u in dendritic layer ℓ , $\delta_{0,u}^{(\ell),a} = \partial L / \partial a_{0,u}^{(\ell)}$ for the corresponding activation-space error when soma activity $a_0 = f_0(V_0)$ is used, δ_0 for the layer-wide soma/core teaching vector used

operationally, $\bar{\delta}$ for the global scalar obtained by averaging soma coordinates within an example, and $\delta_{u,n}^{(\ell)} = \partial L / \partial V_{u,n}^{(\ell)}$ for compartment n of neuron u in layer ℓ . We use α_n^{cond} for the conductance-stage path gain from compartment n to the soma and $\tilde{\alpha}_n$ for the effective path gain after including any post-voltage activation derivatives; when upward transfer is identity, $\tilde{\alpha}_n = \alpha_n^{\text{cond}}$. We use N_E and N_I for the number of excitatory and inhibitory synapses per branch, r_n^{4F} for the empirical 4F branch-soma covariance proxy, ϕ_n for the 5F bounded branch-level preconditioner, λ_{mix} for the pathway-broadcast mixing weight, and κ_j for depth-dependent modulation in morphology extensions. All conductances and presynaptic activities in the main experimental setting are nonnegative; additive voltages may be signed comparators, but the conductance variables that define the shunting model are nonnegative.

Voltage equation and local sensitivities. Consider compartment n with synaptic inputs j (activity x_j , reversal E_j , conductance $g_j^{\text{syn}} \geq 0$) and dendritic inputs from children (voltage V_j , conductance $g_j^{\text{den}} \geq 0$). The steady-state voltage is:

$$V_n = \frac{\sum_j E_j x_j g_j^{\text{syn}} + \sum_j V_j g_j^{\text{den}}}{\underbrace{\sum_j x_j g_j^{\text{syn}} + \sum_j g_j^{\text{den}} + 1}_{g_n^{\text{tot}}}}, \quad R_n^{\text{tot}} = 1/g_n^{\text{tot}}. \quad (1)$$

V_n is a convex combination of reversal potentials, child voltages, and leak. Writing $\mathcal{S}_n = \{0\} \cup \{E_j\}_j \cup \{V_j\}_j$, we have $\min \mathcal{S}_n \leq V_n \leq \max \mathcal{S}_n$ and $0 < R_n^{\text{tot}} \leq 1$. The local sensitivities follow directly:

Proposition 1 (Local Sensitivities).

$$\frac{\partial V_n}{\partial g_i^{\text{syn}}} = x_i R_n^{\text{tot}} (E_i - V_n), \quad \frac{\partial V_n}{\partial V_i} = g_i^{\text{den}} R_n^{\text{tot}}, \quad \frac{\partial V_n}{\partial g_i^{\text{den}}} = R_n^{\text{tot}} (V_i - V_n). \quad (2)$$

Eq. (2) gives the eligibility factors used by the local rules below: presynaptic activity or voltage difference, driving force, and input resistance. If a child transmits post-voltage activity $a_i = f_i(V_i)$ rather than raw voltage, the dendritic-conductance derivative is $R_n^{\text{tot}}(a_i - V_n)$ and the child-voltage error includes the local factor $f'_i(V_i)$.

Shunting inhibition as divisive gain control. An inhibitory synapse with $E_{\text{inh}} \approx 0$ contributes current $(0 - V_n)x_j g_j^{\text{syn}}$ and increases g_n^{tot} . Its sensitivity is $\partial V_n / \partial g_j^{\text{syn}} = -x_j R_n^{\text{tot}} V_n$, which corresponds to multiplicative attenuation (divisive normalization). Shunting is divisive at the voltage level, but its effect on firing rates can be subtractive in some regimes [10]. Inhibitory plasticity can balance excitation dynamically [11]; our learned inhibitory conductances provide a trainable balancing mechanism. The same denominator also gives the direct connection to path gain. Writing $G_n^E(x)$ and $G_n^I(x)$ for the total excitatory and inhibitory synaptic conductance impinging on compartment n ,

$$R_n^{\text{tot}}(x) = (1 + G_n^E(x) + G_n^I(x) + G_n^{\text{den}})^{-1}.$$

Increasing $G_n^I(x)$ lowers $R_n^{\text{tot}}(x)$ and therefore multiplicatively suppresses every upstream path whose error must pass through compartment n . In this sense inhibition can gate credit flow by changing the path gain, even when the inhibitory drive is feedforward rather than lateral. Prop. 2 formalizes this statement after the tree path gain is defined.

Exact gradients for dendritic trees. For one neuron/tree in layer ℓ , let $V_{0,u}^{(\ell)}$ be the somatic voltage and define the exact voltage-space soma error as $\delta_{0,u}^{(\ell),V} := \partial L / \partial V_{0,u}^{(\ell)}$. If a decoder receives soma activity $a_0 = f_0(V_0)$ rather than raw voltage, the decoder supplies an activation-space error δ_0^a and the voltage-space boundary is $\delta_0^V = f'_0(V_0)\delta_0^a$. The theoretical derivation is stated for the conductance-stage voltage before any post-voltage reactivation. When a branch applies a monotone reactivation before transmitting activity upward, the same recursion holds with additional local derivative factors along the path. All exact-error diagnostics below are computed as pre-reactivation voltage errors, including activation-derivative factors when reactivation is enabled.

Theorem 1 (Conductance-Stage Backpropagation on a Dendritic Tree). *For a rooted dendritic tree with soma at node 0 and unique parent $p(n)$ for each non-somatic compartment, suppose the parent*

receives either the pre-reactivation voltage V_n or a local post-voltage activity $a_n = f_n(V_n)$. For identity upward transfer, the loss gradient satisfies

$$\frac{\partial L}{\partial V_n} = \frac{\partial L}{\partial V_{p(n)}} R_{p(n)}^{\text{tot}} g_{n \rightarrow p(n)}^{\text{den}}, \quad (3)$$

with boundary condition $\partial L / \partial V_0 = \delta_0^V$. With post-voltage transfer $a_n = f_n(V_n)$, the local factor is the product of $f'_n(V_n)$, $R_{p(n)}^{\text{tot}}$, and $g_{n \rightarrow p(n)}^{\text{den}}$. Because the graph is a tree, each compartment has a unique path to the soma. Defining the conductance-stage path gain

$$\alpha_n^{\text{cond}} = \prod_{(i \rightarrow k) \in \text{path}(n \rightsquigarrow 0)} R_k^{\text{tot}} g_{i \rightarrow k}^{\text{den}}, \quad \frac{\partial L}{\partial V_n} = \alpha_n^{\text{cond}} \delta_0^V, \quad (4)$$

with $\alpha_0^{\text{cond}} = 1$ under identity transfer. In the post-voltage case, the exact effective path gain is

$$\tilde{\alpha}_n = \prod_{(i \rightarrow k) \in \text{path}(n \rightsquigarrow 0)} f'_i(V_i) R_k^{\text{tot}} g_{i \rightarrow k}^{\text{den}}, \quad \frac{\partial L}{\partial V_n} = \tilde{\alpha}_n \delta_0^V, \quad (5)$$

where $f'_i(V_i)$ is omitted for identity transfer.

Proof. Apply the chain rule on the tree-structured computation graph using Prop. 1. $\square$

The one-step recursion in Eq. (3) and the path product in Eq. (4) separate local conductance transfer from the non-local somatic error for one soma/tree and one layer. Supplying an approximate layer-soma teaching vector, reusing a decoder-derived vector at another layer, or compressing $\delta_{0,u}^{(\ell),V}$ into a per-soma or global scalar broadcast is an additional feedback-approximation step introduced by LocalCA, not a consequence of the theorem itself.

Proposition 2 (Inhibitory control of conductance-stage path gain). *Let $\mathcal{A}(n)$ be the set of compartments on the path from compartment n to the soma, excluding n and including the parent compartments through which the error must pass. Holding dendritic coupling conductances fixed, an added inhibitory conductance $\Delta G_k^I(x) \geq 0$ at any $k \in \mathcal{A}(n)$ changes the conductance-stage path gain by*

$$\frac{\alpha_n^{\text{cond}}(x; \Delta G^I)}{\alpha_n^{\text{cond}}(x; 0)} = \prod_{k \in \mathcal{A}(n)} \frac{g_k^{\text{tot}}(x)}{g_k^{\text{tot}}(x) + \Delta G_k^I(x)}, \quad \frac{\partial \log \alpha_n^{\text{cond}}}{\partial G_k^I} = \begin{cases} -R_k^{\text{tot}}, & k \in \mathcal{A}(n), \\ 0, & k \notin \mathcal{A}(n). \end{cases} \quad (6)$$

Proof. Substitute $R_k^{\text{tot}} = 1/g_k^{\text{tot}}$ into the path-gain product in Eq. (4). Adding inhibitory conductance changes only the denominator at compartments on the path from n to the soma, which gives the product ratio and the log derivative in Eq. (6). $\square$

Prop. 2 makes two directed predictions. First, inhibition is a path gate: it attenuates all credit paths below the inhibited compartment. Second, inhibition is useful for restricted-feedback local learning only when this attenuation makes the distribution of α_n^{cond} more uniform or better aligned with the task. If inhibition is too strong, too heterogeneous, or generated by a poorly calibrated inhibitory population, it can suppress useful signals and hurt learning. In the additive control the same inhibitory input changes voltages and local eligibilities, but it does not enter the conductance-stage path recursion as a multiplicative resistance gate.

When does shunting compress path gains? The attenuation identity above is not by itself a concentration result. Let $z_n = \log \alpha_n^{\text{cond}}$ be the log conductance-stage path gain for compartment n . If added inhibitory conductance contributes a path-dependent attenuation

$$\beta_n(x) = \sum_{k \in \mathcal{A}(n)} \log \left(1 + \frac{\Delta G_k^I(x)}{g_k^{\text{tot}}(x)} \right), \quad z'_n = z_n - \beta_n, \quad (7)$$

then, over compartments or examples,

$$\text{Var}(z') = \text{Var}(z) + \text{Var}(\beta) - 2 \text{Cov}(z, \beta). \quad (8)$$

Thus, shunting narrows the log path-gain field exactly when

$$\text{Cov}(z, \beta) > \frac{1}{2} \text{Var}(\beta). \quad (9)$$

Eq. (7) follows by taking the logarithm of the product ratio in Prop. 2; Eq. (8) then applies the variance identity for $z - \beta$. Eq. (9) is a diagnostic condition under one averaging measure, not the empirical mechanism claimed below. In finite trained networks, the covariance margin can disagree with CV and exact-error-rank summaries because these statistics average over different compartment and sample axes. We therefore use direct path-gain dispersion, exact-error compressibility, and inhibition-intervention measurements as the empirical tests, and report the covariance margin as a boundary check in the appendix.

Corollary 1 (Local-Global Factorization). *The exact synaptic gradient at compartment n factorizes as:*

$$\frac{\partial L}{\partial g_i^{\text{syn}}} = \underbrace{x_i R_n^{\text{tot}} (E_i - V_n)}_{\text{synapse-local eligibility}} \cdot \underbrace{\frac{\partial L}{\partial V_n}}_{\text{compartment error}}, \quad (10)$$

where the eligibility term depends only on quantities available at synapse i (presynaptic activity x_i , input resistance R_n^{tot} , driving force $E_i - V_n$), and the compartment error $\partial L / \partial V_n$ is the sole non-local quantity.

Exact-gradient reconstruction uses the measured R_n^{tot} from the forward pass. A biological implementation need not explicitly represent this factor with numerical precision: if branch resistance varies slowly, it can be approximated or absorbed into branch-specific plasticity gain, and it provides a natural site for neuromodulatory regulation of learning rate.

Proposition 3 (Path-gain dispersion controls 3F alignment). *For a single example before batch averaging, consider one soma/tree with the exact voltage-space soma error δ_0^V supplied, and write the local eligibility for conductance parameter i as z_i . Let $n(i)$ be the compartment containing parameter i . Under identity transfer replace $\tilde{\alpha}_{n(i)}$ below by $\alpha_{n(i)}^{\text{cond}}$; with post-voltage transfer use the effective gain $\tilde{\alpha}_{n(i)}$. Assume both gradient vectors are nonzero, equivalently $\sum_i w_i > 0$ and $\sum_i w_i \tilde{\alpha}_{n(i)}^2 > 0$. The exact and 3F per-soma gradients are*

$$g_i^{\text{BP}} = z_i \tilde{\alpha}_{n(i)} \delta_0^V, \quad \hat{g}_i^{\text{3F}} = z_i \delta_0^V. \quad (11)$$

If transfer derivatives and conductance couplings are nonnegative, $\tilde{\alpha}_{n(i)} \geq 0$, so corresponding nonzero components have the same sign. Their cosine is

$$\cos(\hat{g}^{\text{3F}}, g^{\text{BP}}) = \frac{\sum_i w_i \tilde{\alpha}_{n(i)}}{\sqrt{\sum_i w_i} \sqrt{\sum_i w_i \tilde{\alpha}_{n(i)}^2}} = \frac{1}{\sqrt{1 + \text{CV}_w(\tilde{\alpha}_{n(i)}^2)}}, \quad w_i = (z_i \delta_0^V)^2. \quad (12)$$

Proof. Substitute Eq. (11) into the cosine formula and cancel the common signed eligibility factors through w_i . The final equality is the weighted identity $E_w[\tilde{\alpha}^2] = E_w[\tilde{\alpha}]^2(1 + \text{CV}_w(\tilde{\alpha}^2))$. $\square$

Prop. 3 is conditional on the exact layer-soma error. It explains why low effective path-gain dispersion is a useful within-tree credit geometry, while also making clear that practical multi-layer LocalCA must approximate the layer-soma error before this within-tree argument applies. The factorization in Eq. (10) isolates the fast task-error-dependent non-local quantity as $\partial L / \partial V_n = \alpha_n^{\text{cond}} \delta_0^V$ under identity upward transfer and $\partial L / \partial V_n = \tilde{\alpha}_n \delta_0^V$ when post-voltage transfer is enabled. The implemented updates in Eqs. (13)–(14) are batch averages of products, so Prop. 3 should be read as the pre-batch geometry of per-example gradient contributions. The 4F and 5F factors introduced below use slower voltage statistics, so they are empirical reliability preconditioners rather than additional error signals. Any practical local rule therefore depends on how well its broadcast signal approximates that exact compartment error, which we evaluate in the gradient-fidelity diagnostic below. In the models studied here, shunting improves this approximation by reducing and stabilizing R_n^{tot} , which narrows the spread of local sensitivities across the tree. In the empirical networks, each dendritic branch layer may optionally apply a post-voltage reactivation $f(V_n)$ before passing activity to the next stage; unless otherwise noted, the manuscript sweeps use a learnable bounded tanh reactivation.

3 Local Learning Rules

Broadcast error approximation. We approximate the exact compartment error $\partial L/\partial V_n$ (Corollary 1) with a broadcast signal e_n^V derived from a soma/core teaching vector. For a linear readout this vector is $W_{\text{dec}}^\top (\partial L/\partial \hat{y})$; for a nonlinear decoder we use the corresponding decoder-input Jacobian product $J_{\text{dec}}(h_{\text{core}})^\top (\partial L/\partial \hat{y})$ so that feedback is defined in soma/core coordinates. If this vector is used at an earlier matched-width dendritic layer, practical LocalCA assumes neuron-index correspondence and reuses the coordinate as an approximate layer-soma error. This inter-layer teaching approximation is distinct from the within-tree question addressed by Theorem 1: given a layer-soma error, how faithfully can a restricted branch-level field approximate $\partial L/\partial V_n$? The main matched-capacity performance and mechanism runs use per-soma feedback: when soma/core dimension matches a layer’s neuron dimension, each neuron receives one soma-specific teaching coordinate and the same value is shared across that neuron’s dendritic compartments. Conditional on an exact layer-soma error, per-soma sharing isolates the within-tree approximation. Practical multi-layer LocalCA additionally approximates earlier-layer soma errors by reusing final-core coordinates at matched-width layers, as separated explicitly in Fig. 2D. A stricter scalar mode compresses the soma/core vector to one number per example, $\bar{\delta}_b = d_0^{-1} \sum_{c=1}^{d_0} \delta_{0,bc}^a$, and broadcasts that number to all neurons and compartments. Thus scalar feedback also discards heterogeneity across soma-error coordinates. For higher-bandwidth controls, P_K is a fixed random projection from soma-error coordinates to K feedback channels, $q_{n,k}$ are fixed compartment-specific mixing coefficients, and Γ_n denotes the pathway-structured transport map for compartment n . We distinguish five feedback objects: **global scalar broadcast**, $e_n = \bar{\delta} \mathbf{1}$; **per-soma shared broadcast**, $e_{u,n}$ is one coordinate shared across the compartments of neuron u ; **rank- K random broadcast**, $c = P_K \delta_0^a$ and $e_n = \sum_k q_{n,k} c_k$; **path-structured broadcast**, $e_n = \lambda_{\text{mix}} \bar{\delta} \mathbf{1} + (1 - \lambda_{\text{mix}}) \Gamma_n(\delta_0^a)$ with pathway roles motivated by vectorized dendritic teaching signals [45]; and the **transported oracle**, $e_n^{\text{transport}} = \tilde{\alpha}_n \delta_0^V = \partial L/\partial V_n$, an analysis upper bound because it supplies the exact path-transported compartment error from Theorem 1. When reactivation is enabled, exact path transport includes the activation derivatives along the branch-to-soma path. The final local voltage-space error is then obtained by multiplying the branch activation-space error by the local derivative $f'_n(V_n)$; with identity transfer, this reduces to $\alpha_n^{\text{cond}} \delta_0^V$. Thus, the main feedforward result tests neuron-wise/per-soma feedback rather than a single layer-wide scalar. Under shunting, this restricted field supports nontrivial learning on the standard classification tasks, while scalar, routed, and rank-bridge controls in the appendix expose regimes where lower-bandwidth feedback collapses branch identity and richer feedback is needed. A local-mismatch heuristic is included only as an appendix control because it performs much worse than the somatic-error broadcasts (Appendix A).

Three-factor learning rule (3F).

Definition 1 (3F Update). *For synaptic and dendritic conductances, with $a_j = V_j$ under identity upward transfer and $a_j = f_j(V_j)$ when post-voltage transfer is enabled:*

$$\hat{\nabla}_{g_j^{\text{syn}}} L = \langle x_j R_n^{\text{tot}} (E_j - V_n) e_n^V \rangle_B, \quad \hat{\nabla}_{g_j^{\text{den}}} L = \langle R_n^{\text{tot}} (a_j - V_n) e_n^V \rangle_B, \quad (13)$$

where $\langle \cdot \rangle_B$ denotes the batch average.

The three factors are presynaptic activity x_j (or a transmitted child activity difference), postsynaptic modulation through driving force and input resistance, and the broadcast voltage-space error e_n^V . The same rule applies to excitatory and inhibitory synapses. The sign difference comes from the driving force $(E_j - V_n)$. We write $\hat{\nabla}_g L$ as the local gradient estimate supplied to the optimizer; the optimizer applies the usual learning rate and descent step. Equivalently, one could absorb the sign convention into e_n^V and treat it as a descent signal.

Additive control. Rule (13) is the local gradient of the *shunting* voltage $V_n = \sum E_j g_j x_j / g_n^{\text{tot}}$. For the additive E/I control, inhibition enters as a fixed signed voltage contribution rather than through the conductance denominator:

$$V_n^{\text{add}} = \sum_{j \in E} g_j^E x_j^E - \sum_{j \in I} g_j^I x_j^I + \sum_k g_k^{\text{den}} a_k.$$

Equivalently, $\partial V_n^{\text{add}} / \partial g_j^{\text{syn}} = s_j x_j$ with $s_j = +1$ for excitatory and $s_j = -1$ for inhibitory synapses, and $\partial V_n^{\text{add}} / \partial g_k^{\text{den}} = a_k$. The additive local gradient therefore has no driving-force or R_n^{tot} terms ($R_n^{\text{tot}} \equiv 1$ by definition since there is no denominator). For the identity-transfer additive tree, the exact

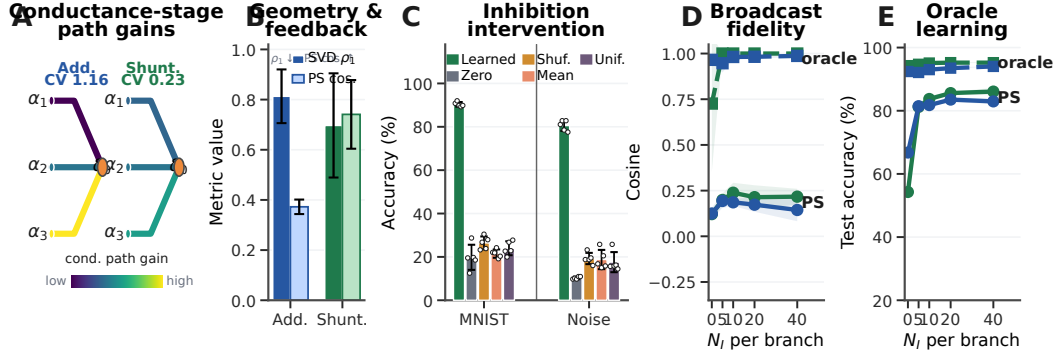


Figure 3: **Mechanistic chain from path gains to learning.** (A) Conductance-stage path-gain field α^{cond} . (B) MNIST exact-error geometry and implemented-feedback compatibility: unrestricted rank-1 SVD residual ρ_1 (lower is better) and actual per-soma broadcast cosine (higher is better). (C) Post-training inhibitory-conductance interventions. (D,E) Broadcast fidelity and transported-error learning on noise resilience. CV, ρ_1 , per-soma cosine, and interventions: Appendix A. Error bars are ± 1 s.d.

upward gain is $\alpha_n^{\text{add}} = \prod_{(i \rightarrow k) \in \text{path}(n \rightsquigarrow 0)} g_{i \rightarrow k}^{\text{den}}$; with reactivation, $\tilde{\alpha}_n^{\text{add}} = \prod_{(i \rightarrow k)} f'_i(V_i) g_{i \rightarrow k}^{\text{den}}$. Thus additive controls have an exact tree gain, but inhibition does not enter that gain through a conductance denominator. Throughout, each architecture uses the learning rule derived from its own forward-pass dynamics. This keeps the comparison architecture-matched rather than applying a shunting-derived rule to an additive model. In implementations with unconstrained raw parameters θ and $g = \text{softplus}(\theta)$, Eqs. (13)–(14) give conductance-space gradients; before assigning gradients to θ , we multiply by $\partial g / \partial \theta$. The exact-gradient reconstruction diagnostics include this parameterization factor; Appendix B gives the compact shunting/additive comparison.

Practical heuristic wrappers: 4F and 5F. The 4F and 5F variants add slow branch-level preconditioners to the same fast eligibility and broadcast error; they are empirical stabilizers, not additional task-error channels. 4F uses a branch-soma covariance proxy and 5F adds a bounded predictability factor,

$$r_n^{4F} = \frac{\text{Cov}_B(\bar{V}_{n,b}, \bar{V}_{0,b})}{\sqrt{\text{Var}_B(\bar{V}_{n,b}) \text{Var}_B(\bar{V}_{0,b})} + \varepsilon}, \quad \phi_n = \frac{\text{Var}(V_n)}{\sigma_{\text{res}}^2 + \varepsilon},$$

with implementation clamps $r_n^{4F} \in [0.1, 2.0]$ and $\phi_n \in [0.25, 4.0]$. The appendix specifies the averaging axes, EMA initialization, detaching, and clamp rationale. Empirically, 4F alone gives little improvement over 3F; the practical rule is the 5F update below.

Definition 2 (5F Update).

$$\hat{\nabla}_{g_j^{\text{syn}}} L = r_n^{4F} \phi_n \langle x_j R_n^{\text{tot}} (E_j - V_n) e_n^V \rangle_B, \quad \hat{\nabla}_{g_j^{\text{den}}} L = r_n^{4F} \phi_n \langle R_n^{\text{tot}} (a_j - V_n) e_n^V \rangle_B. \quad (14)$$

Eq. (14) is therefore the main practical LocalCA update; Algorithm 1 (Appendix B) gives the full forward-pass-to-weight-update order. The 3F rule uses the theorem-derived local eligibility with an approximate broadcast error, while 4F and 5F add empirical reliability factors. A feedback-alignment-style random-broadcast argument is included in Appendix C; it is supportive but not central to the main mechanism claim.

4 Experiments

Setup. The experiments test factorization, gradient fidelity, exact-error geometry, functional dependence on learned inhibition, and transported-error oracles using architecture-matched additive/shunting cores and local/backprop training on MNIST [43], Fashion-MNIST [42], figure-ground MNIST, and noise resilience; CIFAR-10 [44], cue routing, DFA, and detailed protocols are in the appendix. Unless stated otherwise, local runs use 5F with per-soma feedback, conductance runs use nonnegative first-layer drive, and main mechanism/oracle/performance results use five seeds. Transported error is an oracle upper bound from Theorem 1, not the proposed biological rule. Figure shorthand: BP backpropagation, PS per-soma feedback, PT exact path transport, PV pathway-vector

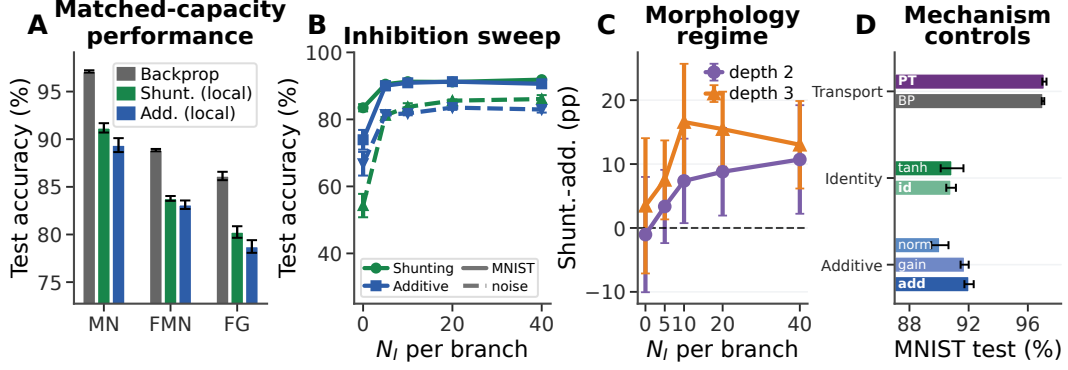


Figure 4: Matched-capacity performance and regime dependence. (A) Matched shunting backpropagation reference vs. per-soma 5F LocalCA; additive backpropagation references are reported in Table S4 where matched five-seed runs are available. (B) Inhibitory dose-response. (C) Morphology-dependent shunting advantage. (D) MNIST controls: BP, exact path transport (PT), activation choice, and additive gain/normalization variants. Values/protocols: Table S4; Appendix A. Error bars denote ± 1 s.d.

301 feedback, Or. transported oracle, K random low-rank channels, N_I inhibitory synapses/branch,
 302 pp percentage points, and MN/FM/FG = MNIST/Fashion-MNIST/figure-ground MNIST. Metrics,
 303 implementation, and tasks are defined in Appendices A, B, and D.

304 *From exact factorization to credit-signal fidelity.* We compare local and backprop gradients
 305 on matched batches and parameters using parameter-count-weighted cosine and scale mismatch
 306 $|\log_{10}(\|g_p^{\text{local}}\|/\|g_p^{\text{bp}}\|)|$. Shunting improves the final diagnostic, though absolute directional agree-
 307 ment remains weak: cosine rises from 0.005 ± 0.026 to 0.100 ± 0.033 , and scale mismatch falls from
 308 0.50 ± 0.05 to 0.26 ± 0.05 . Exact-gradient reconstruction matches autograd to numerical precision
 309 (Fig. 2A). The layer-soma factorial diagnostic separates the two practical approximations: exact layer-
 310 soma errors plus path transport recover autograd, while per-soma compression and reused final-core
 311 coordinates mainly damage the first layer (Fig. 2D). Thus the central non-local approximation is the
 312 broadcast substitute for $\partial L/\partial V_n$, not the tree recursion.

313 *Mechanistic chain: path gains, broadcast fidelity, and oracle transport.* Figure 3 gives the central
 314 empirical chain. At matched inhibition ($N_I=5$), shunting narrows the MNIST conductance-stage path-
 315 gain component (CV 0.23 vs. 1.16 for additive), lowers the unrestricted rank-1 residual (0.70 ± 0.21
 316 vs. 0.81 ± 0.11), and improves compatibility with the implemented feedback field (actual per-soma
 317 broadcast cosine 0.74 ± 0.13 vs. 0.37 ± 0.18). Panel A reports the conductance-stage component
 318 α^{cond} and is an architectural path-gain diagnostic rather than a direct validation of Prop. 3; the
 319 appendix defines the corresponding effective-gain diagnostics when reactivation is enabled. The
 320 SVD and broadcast-cosine bars test intrinsic geometry and implemented-feedback compatibility,
 321 respectively.

322 Learned branch inhibition is functionally important: zeroing, shuffling, or clamping it drops MNIST
 323 from about 90% to 20–26% and noise resilience from about 81% to 10–19%. Direct fidelity and
 324 oracle panels probe the same bottleneck: under shunting, per-soma feedback better tracks exact
 325 compartment errors, transported-error fidelity approaches 0.95–1.0, and transported learning lifts
 326 both architectures to 92–95% on noise resilience.

327 *Matched-capacity performance.* In the matched-capacity regime, shunting LocalCA remains within
 328 5–6 percentage points of matched backpropagation on MNIST, Fashion-MNIST, and figure-ground
 329 MNIST (Table S4; Fig. 4). Controls in Fig. 4D identify a feedback-field bottleneck: exact path
 330 transport reaches the matched shunting backprop reference, activation choice has little effect, and
 331 additive gain/normalization variants do not rescue the additive baseline. Fig. 5 shows that 5F is
 332 the strongest practical LocalCA variant, soma-derived feedback is essential, and higher-rank/path
 333 feedback improves the noise-resilience bridge.

334 *Regime dependence of the shunting advantage.* With matched per-soma feedback, shunting is
 335 modestly better on MNIST, Fashion-MNIST, and figure-ground MNIST, and the gap grows on
 336 inhibition-sensitive noise resilience. Morphology shifts the useful inhibitory regime, so the shunting
 337 advantage is not monotonic in N_I or tree depth (Fig. 4B,C; Appendix Fig. S6).

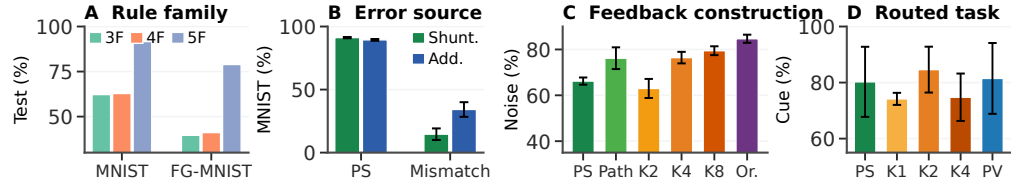


Figure 5: **Rule and feedback controls.** (A) Rule ablation. (B) Error-source ablation. (C) Noise-resilience feedback ladder: PS, path proxy, low-rank K , and transported oracle. (D) Cue-routing rank diagnostic with pathway-vector feedback (PV). Details: Appendix Fig. S1; Table S8.

5 Discussion

We studied local credit assignment in conductance-based dendritic networks with explicit E/I conductance synapses, shunting inhibition, and tree-structured branching. Exact gradients separate synapse-local eligibility–presynaptic activity, driving force, and input resistance—from one path-specific compartment error, making LocalCA an error-approximation problem. The experiments support a coherent mechanism: branching creates credit paths, E/I synapse banks set the conductance state, and shunting modulates input resistance along those paths. In the regimes studied here this lowers exact-error rank, improves feedback-fidelity diagnostics, reduces gradient-scale mismatch, and lets transported-error oracles substantially reduce the local-learning gap. Post-training interventions further show that learned inhibitory conductance is sample-dependent and functionally important to the trained forward computation.

The operating regime matters. Shunting is not universally beneficial, more inhibition is not always better, and the practical 5F rule is an empirical bounded preconditioner. Exact decoder-to-soma feedback requires the decoder Jacobian or linear readout to supply the correct soma/core coordinate; practical multi-layer LocalCA also approximates layer-soma errors by reusing coordinates at earlier matched-width layers. The core theorem covers conductance-stage branch parameters under steady-state, non-spiking dynamics; reactivation, decoder, router, top- k , 4F/5F batch-time statistics, and HSIC terms are implementation-specific updates. Learned synapse selection may also reshape the eligibility basis so a fixed or low-rank feedback field aligns better with active synaptic drive, analogous in spirit to DFA alignment, but we treat this as a hypothesis for future diagnostics rather than a demonstrated mechanism here. Eq. (9) is interpretive, and activation shape, morphology, task structure, and feedback rank can change broadcast compatibility. The inhibition studied here is input-driven rather than recurrent lateral inhibition, and post-training interventions establish forward necessity rather than isolating credit-assignment causality. We therefore claim a credit-geometry mechanism supported by exact reconstruction, fidelity diagnostics, controls, and oracle transport, not competitive CIFAR-10 performance or sufficiency of a single global scalar broadcast for routed/pathway-specific tasks.

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A Supplementary Empirical Results

This appendix records the supporting diagnostics, implementation details, and task protocols needed to interpret the paper’s main claims. It is organized as a reading path rather than as a chronological log: this section contains empirical diagnostics and boundary cases; Appendix B gives the implemented model and optimizer details; Appendix C collects theory-adjacent extensions; and Appendix D defines benchmark and synthetic-task protocols.

Scope notes. Several controls are intentionally negative or mixed. The log-gain covariance margin from Eq. (9) is not used as a positive main result, and the pathway-vector feedback variant does not beat the best unstructured low-rank cue-routing control. These diagnostics delimit the claim rather than smoothing over failure modes.

Symbol	Name	Meaning in this manuscript
V_n, a_n	Compartment voltage/activity	Conductance-stage voltage and optional post-voltage activity $a_n = f_n(V_n)$ for compartment n .
$g^{\text{syn}}, g^{\text{den}}$	Synaptic and dendritic conductances	Nonnegative conductance parameters for branch synapses and child-to-parent coupling.
R_n^{tot}	Input resistance	Reciprocal of total conductance at compartment n ; the implementation uses the stabilized $R_{n,e}^{\text{tot}}$.
$E_j - V_n$	Driving force	Difference between synaptic reversal potential and local voltage; multiplies presynaptic drive in conductance eligibility.
$\delta_{0,u}^{(\ell),V}, \delta_{0,u}^{(\ell),a}$	Soma voltage/activity error	Exact layer-soma error for neuron u in layer ℓ , before or after post-voltage activation.
$\delta_{u,n}^{(\ell)}$	Compartment error	Exact pre-activation voltage-space error for compartment n of neuron u in layer ℓ .
$\delta_0, \bar{\delta}$	Broadcast source coordinates	Soma/core teaching vector and its global scalar average used by restricted-feedback controls.
$\alpha_n^{\text{cond}}, \tilde{\alpha}_n$	Path gain	Conductance-stage and activation-derivative-corrected gain transporting soma error to compartment n .
e_n^V	Broadcast voltage-space error	LocalCA approximation to the exact compartment error used in the 3F–5F updates.
r_n^{4F}, ϕ_n	Branch-level preconditioners	Slowly estimated 4F covariance proxy and 5F bounded predictability factor.
N_E, N_I	Synapse counts	Excitatory and inhibitory synapses per dendritic branch.

Table S1: **Notation reference.** Main symbols used in the derivation, local-learning rules, and diagnostics.

A.1 Reproducibility Statement

Reproducibility is documented at a protocol level in this manuscript. The accompanying source package contains the core model and training code, diagnostic utilities, representative configuration files, tests, figure-source summaries, and analysis scripts used for the manuscript. Table S2 summarizes the experiment families, seed protocols, and checkpoint-selection rules. Code will be released publicly at the time of arXiv posting with an immutable repository tag, pinned environment file, end-to-end launch scripts, and expected summary checks.

Experiment family	Architecture / condition	Seeds	Selection / reporting
Exact-factorization and gradient diagnostics	Nonnegative-input E/I dendritic cores, [128, 128] soma layers, [3, 3] tree, 3F–5F local rules	Five seeds for main summaries; three seeds where indicated for gradient dynamics	Diagnostic batches or fixed checkpoints, reported as gradient/factorization diagnostics
Layer-soma factorial diagnostic	Two-layer shunting checkpoints with exact/reused soma errors and transported/per-soma branch fields	Six fixed checkpoints	Fixed-checkpoint diagnostic; no validation selection
Path-gain, exact-error rank, and inhibition intervention	Matched additive and shunting cores at fixed inhibition; post-training intervention states	Five seeds per main condition	Trained checkpoints; post-training interventions are evaluated on held-out data
Transported-error oracle and feedback-construction controls	Per-soma, random low-rank, path-structured, and exact transported-error feedback	Five seeds for main oracle and feedback-ladder summaries	Validation-selected checkpoints; held-out test summaries
Matched-capacity performance	MNIST, Fashion-MNIST, figure-ground MNIST; per-soma 5F LocalCA and matched backpropagation references	Five seeds	Validation-selected configurations; held-out test accuracy

Table S2: **Protocol-level reproducibility summary.** The table records the experiment families, model settings, seed counts, and selection rules used in the manuscript. Dependency specifications are provided through `requirements.txt`, `pyproject.toml`, and `setup/environment.yml`; exact end-to-end commands and summary hashes will be provided with the public repository tag.

A.2 Diagnostic Metrics

The gradient-fidelity diagnostics compare LocalCA and backpropagation gradients at matched parameters and batches. For a parameter block p , let g_p^{local} and g_p^{bp} be the two gradients and let $w_p = \text{numel}(p) / \sum_q \text{numel}(q)$. The reported weighted cosine is

$$C_w = \sum_p w_p \frac{\langle g_p^{\text{local}}, g_p^{\text{bp}} \rangle}{\|g_p^{\text{local}}\|_2 \|g_p^{\text{bp}}\|_2 + \varepsilon},$$

and weighted scale mismatch is

$$S_w = \sum_p w_p \left| \log_{10} \frac{\|g_p^{\text{local}}\|_2 + \varepsilon}{\|g_p^{\text{bp}}\|_2 + \varepsilon} \right|.$$

For exact-error compressibility, we form a matrix E whose rows are examples and whose columns are compartment–neuron coordinates of the exact pre-reactivation compartment error. If $E = U\Sigma V^\top$ and σ_i are the singular values, the unrestricted rank-1 residual and participation rank are

$$\rho_1 = \frac{\sqrt{\sum_{i>1} \sigma_i^2}}{\sqrt{\sum_i \sigma_i^2}}, \quad r_{\text{part}} = \frac{(\sum_i \sigma_i^2)^2}{\sum_i \sigma_i^4}.$$

This is an intrinsic geometry metric: both the sample coefficients and spatial template are chosen in hindsight by SVD. The constrained shared-field residual instead fixes the spatial template to all ones and allows only the best per-example scalar,

$$\rho_1 = \frac{\|E - \text{rowmean}(E)\mathbf{1}^\top\|_F}{\|E\|_F}.$$

The per-soma/blockwise residual matches the practical feedback object more closely. Let Π_{PS} replace, for each sample and soma, all compartments of that soma by their optimal shared coefficient. Then

$$\rho_{\text{PS}} = \frac{\|E - \Pi_{\text{PS}}E\|_F}{\|E\|_F}.$$

The broadcast-conditioned residual uses the actual feedback field B generated by the implemented mode,

$$\rho_{\text{bc}} = \frac{\|E - B\|_F}{\|E\|_F},$$

with a corresponding flattened cosine and, where useful, a globally rescaled version of B . These constrained metrics are emitted by `scripts/measure_error_rank_diagnostics.py` alongside the unrestricted SVD metrics, so intrinsic error geometry and compatibility with the implemented broadcast field can be reported separately. Path-gain dispersion is the coefficient of variation of α_n^{cond} or $\tilde{\alpha}_n$ over the measured sample and compartment field, depending on whether reactivation is enabled. This unweighted architectural statistic differs from the eligibility-weighted $\text{CV}_w(\tilde{\alpha}_{n(i)})$ in Prop. 3. Compartment-error fidelity is the cosine between the tested broadcast field and the exact compartment-error field after flattening over the same sample and compartment axes.

A.3 Rule and Feedback Controls

These controls separate three questions that are deliberately collapsed in the main matched-capacity performance summary: which local-rule wrapper is practical, whether the somatic error source matters, and how performance changes as the feedback field gains bandwidth or path information.

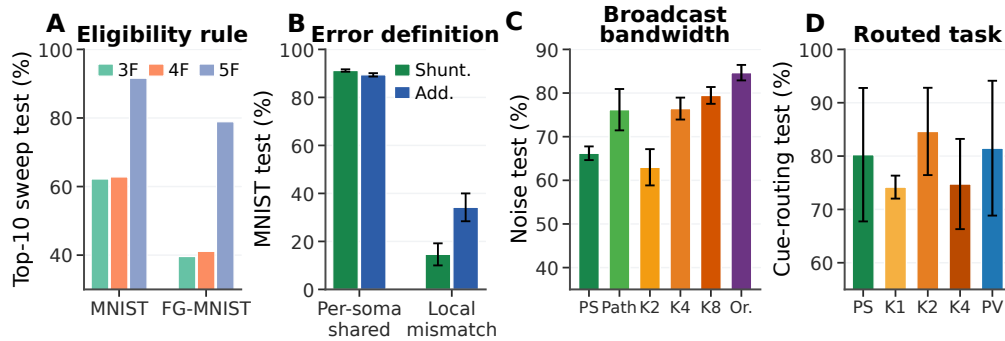


Figure S1: **Detailed rule and feedback controls.** (A) Eligibility-rule ablation: 3F, 4F, and 5F. (B) Error-source ablation: per-soma/shared feedback vs. local mismatch. (C) Feedback-construction ladder on noise resilience: PS per-soma/shared, recursive Path, random low-rank K2/K4/K8, and transported Oracle. (D) Cue routing: PS per-soma/shared, random low-rank K1/K2/K4, and pathway-vector feedback.

A.4 Rule-Family Ranking

Table S3 keeps the 3F/4F/5F optimizer distinction explicit: the theorem-derived eligibility is central to the proposed mechanism, but the reported LocalCA performance results use the empirical 5F stabilizer.

Dataset	Rule	Mean valid, 10 validation-selected configs	Mean test, same 10 configs
MNIST	3F	0.611	0.622
MNIST	4F	0.620	0.628
MNIST	5F	0.912	0.916
Figure-ground MNIST	3F	0.398	0.396
Figure-ground MNIST	4F	0.411	0.411
Figure-ground MNIST	5F	0.807	0.789

Table S3: **Rule-family ranking.** Mean over the ten best validation-selected configurations from local-performance sweeps; this is not top-10 classification accuracy, and test scores are reported only after validation selection.

A.5 5F Stabilizer Sensitivity

Sensitivity checks show that 5F performance is not sharply dependent on the preconditioner clamp or the EMA rate used to estimate branch statistics. Across three-seed MNIST checks, tightening or widening the clamp and varying the EMA rate leaves test accuracy near the default setting, supporting

Dataset	Shunt. BP	Add. BP	Shunt. local	Add. local	Shunt. gap (pp)
MNIST	0.971	0.970 ± 0.001	0.911 ± 0.005	0.894 ± 0.007	6.0
Fashion-MNIST	0.889	0.876 ± 0.001	0.838 ± 0.003	0.831 ± 0.004	5.1
Figure-ground MNIST	0.861	–	0.803 ± 0.006	0.787 ± 0.007	5.8

Table S4: **Local performance.** Backpropagation references are matched-capacity standard-training runs. Additive backpropagation is reported where a matched five-seed reference is available; the figure-ground additive backpropagation reference was not available in the matched five-seed performance outputs. Local values are 5F with per-soma feedback and local decoder updates. The figure-ground LocalCA rows use the HSIC auxiliary objective (weight 0.01); the shunting BP reference is the standard cross-entropy matched-capacity reference. Error bars are ± 1 s.d. across 5 seeds where available; gaps are percentage points.

the view that the factor acts as a bounded branch-level reliability preconditioner rather than a brittle tuned error source.

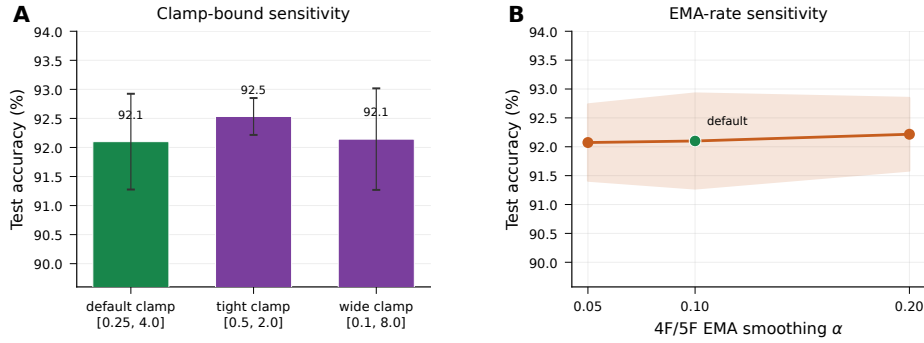


Figure S2: **5F stabilizer sensitivity.** (A) Changing the 5F preconditioner clamp from the default [0.25, 4.0] to tighter [0.5, 2.0] or wider [0.1, 8.0] bounds leaves MNIST test accuracy near 92%. (B) Changing the 4F/5F EMA smoothing rate over $\alpha \in \{0.05, 0.10, 0.20\}$ gives similarly stable performance. Error bars and bands are ± 1 s.d. across 3 seeds.

A.6 Local Performance and Regime Dependence

Table S4 reports the matched-capacity performance numbers used in the main text. The point of this table is not to claim state-of-the-art benchmark performance, but to show the remaining LocalCA-to-backprop gap under matched dendritic capacity and per-soma 5F feedback.

A.7 Extended Gradient Analysis and N_I Sweep Detail

Figure 2 in the main text summarizes final-state gradient diagnostics and the layer-soma factorial check. The supplementary view below (Fig. S3) separates static scale checks, inhibitory dose-response curves, and individual Fashion-MNIST seed behavior so that the aggregate claims are not driven by a single summary panel.

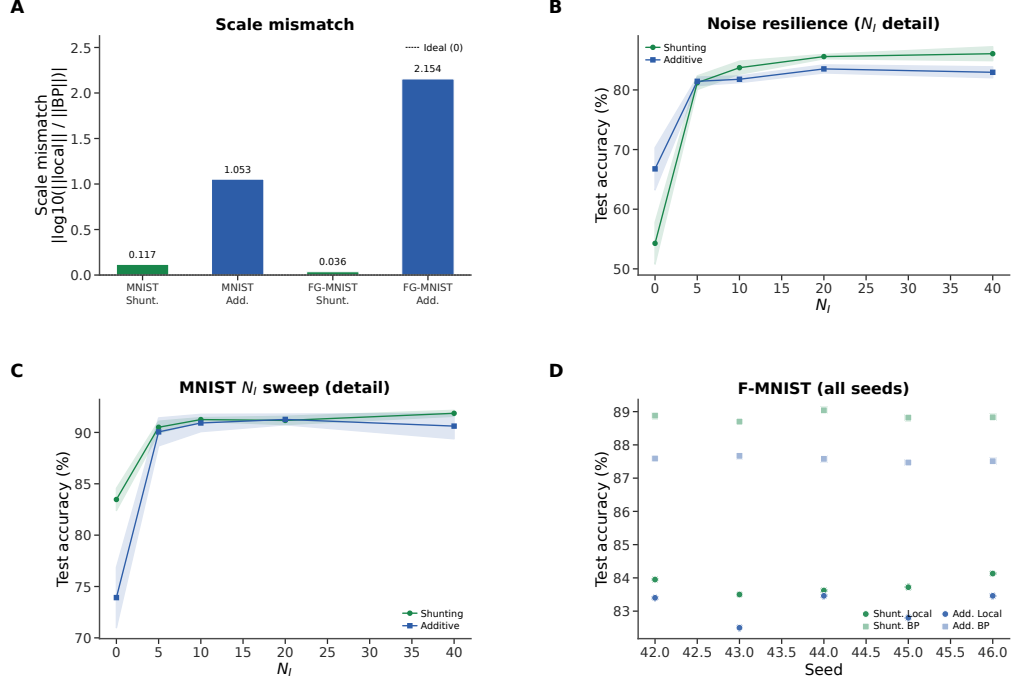


Figure S3: **Extended gradient and N_I analysis (supplementary).** (A) Log-scale mismatch, $|\log_{10}(\|g^{\text{local}}\|/\|g^{\text{BP}}\|)|$, from a separate matched-weight static diagnostic; these values should not be compared directly to the checkpointed final-state diagnostic in Fig. 2. The ideal value is 0; shunting is near ideal (0.117), whereas additive shows order-of-magnitude distortion (> 1.0). (B) Noise-resilience N_I dose-response with error bands (± 1 s.d.). (C) MNIST N_I dose-response detail with error bands. (D) Fashion-MNIST individual seeds for all conditions, showing consistency across runs.

544 **Alignment dynamics.** Local and backprop gradient norms stay finite throughout training, so weak
545 additive alignment reflects directional and scale mismatch rather than vanishing gradients. In a
546 separate 3-seed checkpoint trajectory with parameter-level LocalCA and backprop gradients, additive
547 local gradients remain nonzero (weighted norm range 9.5×10^{-4} – 9.5×10^{-3}), and the corresponding
548 backprop gradients are also nonzero (2.3×10^{-5} – 5.7×10^{-3}). The additive 5F cosine stays near zero
549 from epoch 0 to epoch 50 (0.018 to 0.005), while its local/backprop norm ratio falls from about
550 8.8×10^2 to 0.69 (Fig. S4).

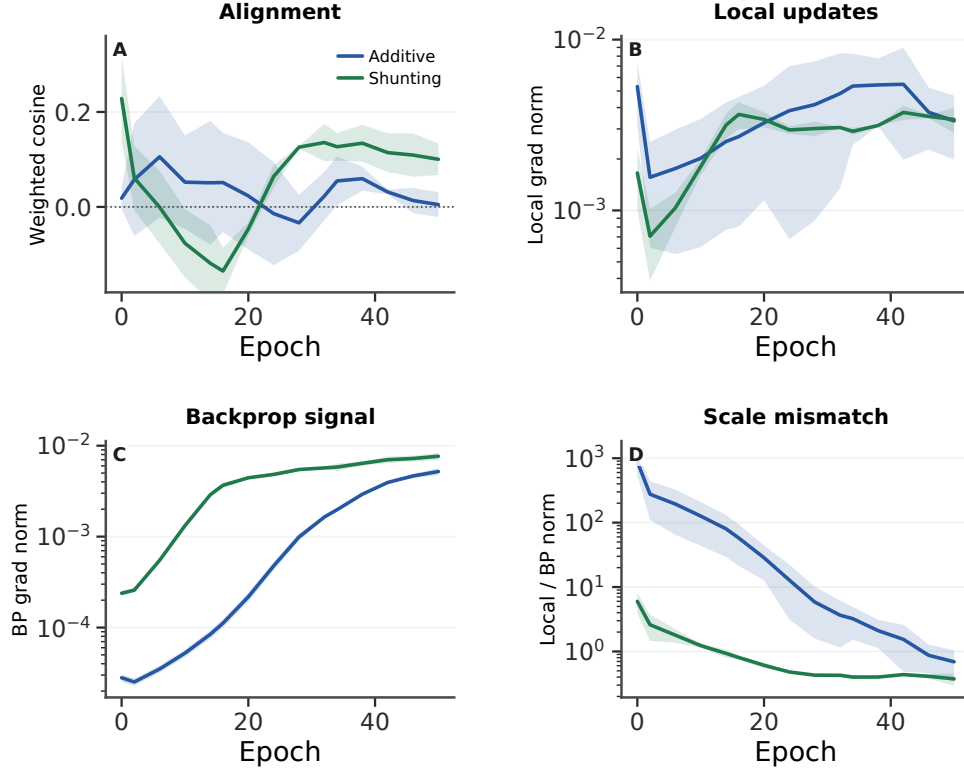


Figure S4: **Alignment dynamics with explicit gradient-norm checks.** (A) Weighted cosine similarity between LocalCA and backpropagation gradients over training for the 5F rule. (B,C) Weighted local and backprop gradient norms stay nonzero for both additive and shunting models. (D) The additive control begins with a much larger scale mismatch, then approaches the backprop scale without recovering strong directional alignment. Shading is s.d. across 3 seeds.

551 A.8 Verification and Seed Robustness

552 These checks (Fig. S5) compare the main seed set with held-out seeds and report the HSIC-weight
 553 sensitivity for figure-ground MNIST. The additional matched experiments use the same objective-
 554 weight comparison on both seed sets, so seed robustness and HSIC contribution can be summarized
 555 as a matched two-factor control.

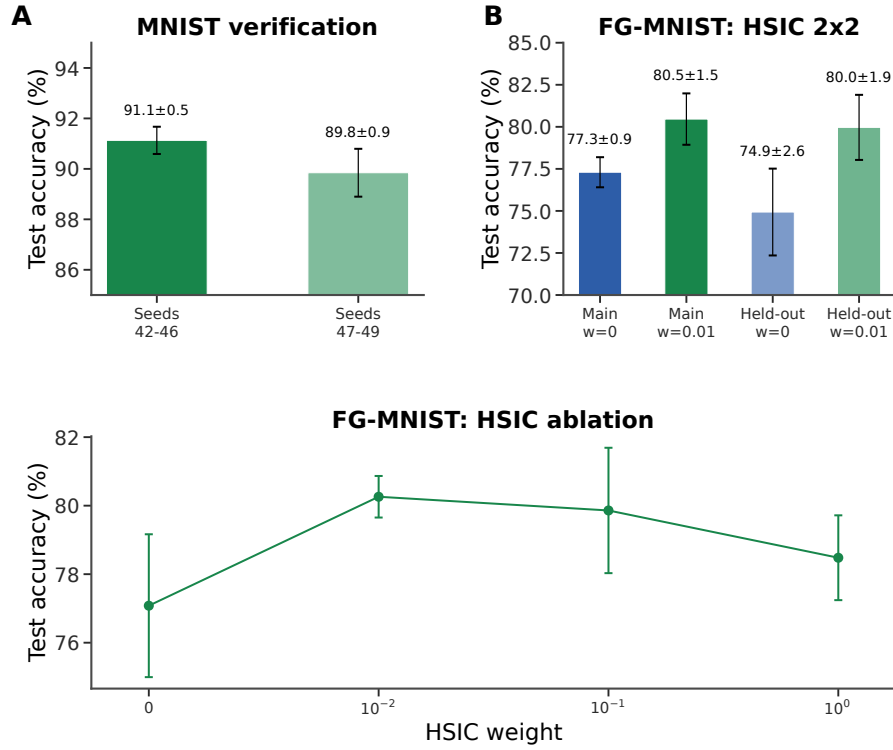


Figure S5: **Verification and seed robustness (supplementary).** (A) MNIST verification: repeat runs on main seeds (42–46) yield $91.1 \pm 0.5\%$; held-out seeds (47–49) yield $89.8 \pm 0.9\%$, showing robustness across random seeds. (B) Matched figure-ground MNIST HSIC control: both main seeds (42–46) and held-out seeds (47–49) compare HSIC weight 0 against 0.01. (C) HSIC weight ablation on figure-ground MNIST: moderate weights (0.01–0.1) perform best.

556 A.9 Additional Stress Tests

557 These stress tests probe two ways in which low-bandwidth broadcast can become unreliable: deeper
 558 dendritic paths and noisy teaching signals. They are not separate main benchmarks; they delimit
 559 where shunting remains useful and where additive local learning degrades.

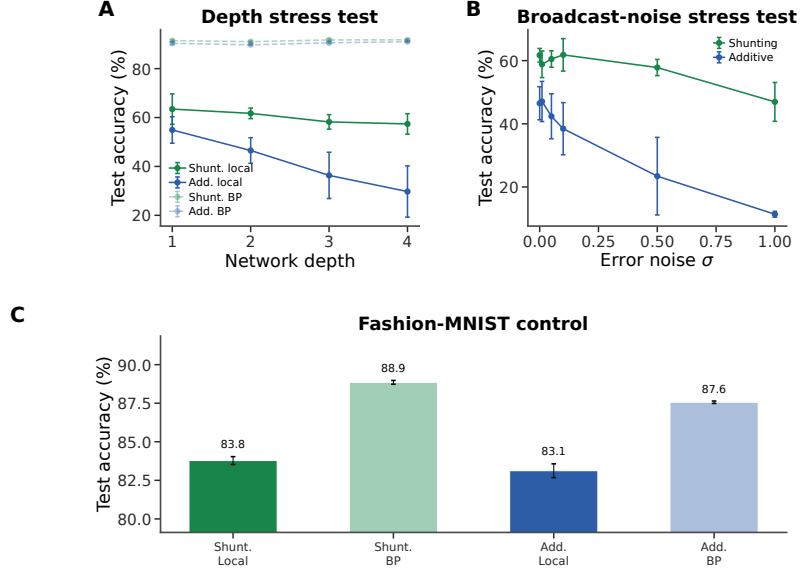


Figure S6: **Additional stress tests.** (A) Depth scaling: shunting local (green) degrades more gracefully from 63.5% to 57.4%; additive local (blue) drops from 54.9% to 29.7%. Matched backpropagation references (dashed) remain stable. (B) Broadcast-noise robustness: shunting remains stable for $\sigma \leq 0.1$; additive degrades rapidly and reaches chance at $\sigma = 1$. (C) Fashion-MNIST: the shunting gain is modest on this cleaner benchmark (83.8% local vs. 88.9% backprop), consistent with the regime-dependent interpretation in the main text.

560 A.10 FA/DFA Baseline Comparison

561 Figure S7 includes feedback alignment as an adjacent local-learning reference point. DFA can be
 562 evaluated on the dendritic cores, whereas the FA condition is marked unavailable for the block-
 563 structured dendritic updates because the required random feedback matrices are not dimensionally
 564 compatible with the branch-level parameterization.

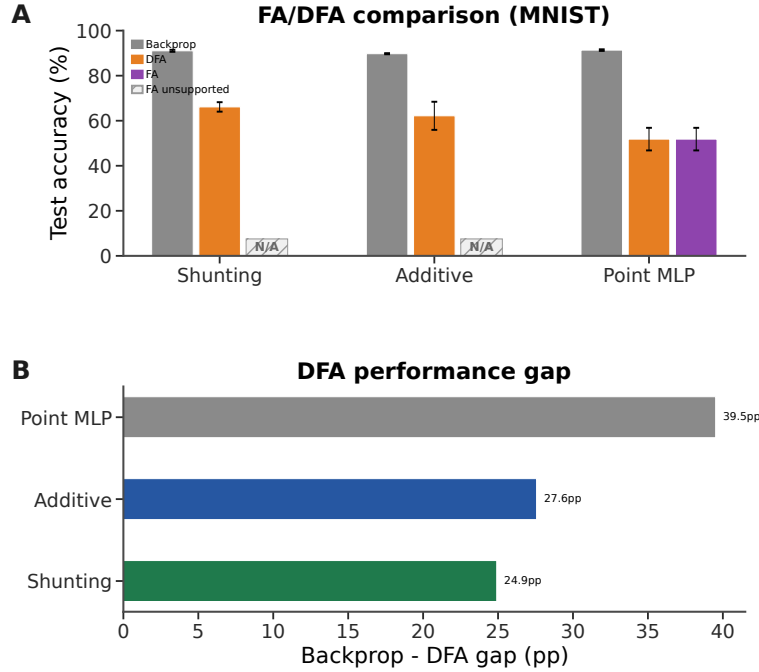


Figure S7: **Feedback alignment baselines (MNIST)**. (A) Grouped comparison: standard backprop (neutral gray), DFA (orange), and FA (purple). Hatched N/A markers indicate that FA is not implemented for the block-structured dendritic architectures because the random feedback matrices are not dimensionally compatible with the tree-structured branch updates. DFA achieves 66.1% on shunting vs. 62.2% additive vs. 51.8% point MLP. (B) Backprop–DFA gap: dendritic architectures (24.9–27.6 pp) show smaller gaps than point MLPs (39.5 pp), suggesting conductance-based architecture is partially compatible with random feedback.

565 A.11 CIFAR-10 Results

566 Figure S8 and Table S5 report a CIFAR-10 control ladder, used as a harder-dataset mechanistic stress
 567 test rather than a competitive vision benchmark.

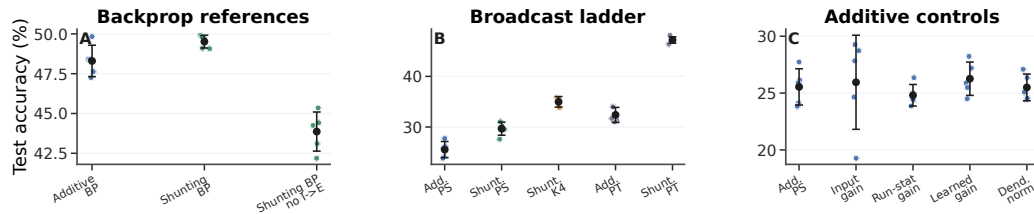


Figure S8: **CIFAR-10 control ladder in the compact direct-I-stream family**. (A) Matched backpropagation references. With nonnegative inputs and a nonlinear decoder, shunting slightly exceeds additive under standard training, and removing learned I-to-E conductance lowers the shunting reference. (B) Broadcast ladder. Per-soma feedback remains weak on this harder dataset, random low-rank $K=4$ improves partially, and exact effective transported error nearly reaches the matched shunting backpropagation reference. (C) Additive fairness controls. Input-dependent gain, running-stat gain, learned gain, and dendritic normalization do not rescue additive per-soma feedback. This figure is a harder-dataset stress test, not a claim of competitive CIFAR-10 benchmarking.

Condition	Core	Training / broadcast	I-to-E	Test acc.
standard	additive	backprop	yes	48.3 ± 1.0
standard	shunting	backprop	yes	49.5 ± 0.4
standard, no learned inhibition	shunting	backprop	no	43.9 ± 1.2
per-soma	additive	5F per-soma	yes	25.5 ± 1.6
per-soma, input-dependent gain	additive	5F per-soma	yes	25.9 ± 4.1
per-soma, running-stat gain	additive	5F per-soma	yes	24.8 ± 0.9
per-soma, learned gain	additive	5F per-soma	yes	26.3 ± 1.5
per-soma, dendritic normalization	additive	5F per-soma	yes	25.5 ± 1.2
per-soma	shunting	5F per-soma	yes	29.7 ± 1.3
per-soma, no learned inhibition	shunting	5F per-soma	no	22.3 ± 0.7
transported error	additive	5F path transport	yes	32.4 ± 1.5
rank-4	shunting	5F low-rank	yes	35.0 ± 1.0
transported error	shunting	5F path transport	yes	47.2 ± 0.6
transported error, no learned inhibition	shunting	5F path transport	no	38.6 ± 1.0

Table S5: **Exact CIFAR-10 values for the 70-run control ladder (5 seeds per condition, validation-best epoch).** All rows use flattened CIFAR-10 in $[0, 1]$, nonnegative transfer outputs, positive conductance transforms, a compact depth-4 dendritic core, and a nonlinear decoder. LocalCA maps output error back to decoder-input/soma coordinates through the decoder Jacobian. The useful conclusions are narrow but important: learned shunting slightly improves the matched backpropagation reference, learned I-to-E conductance is necessary for the strongest shunting results, transported error nearly closes the shunting LocalCA gap, and additive per-soma fairness controls do not explain the transported-shunting result.

A.12 Additive Normalization Control

This control separates generic additive voltage normalization from shunting conductance dynamics in a lower-capacity MNIST stress regime.

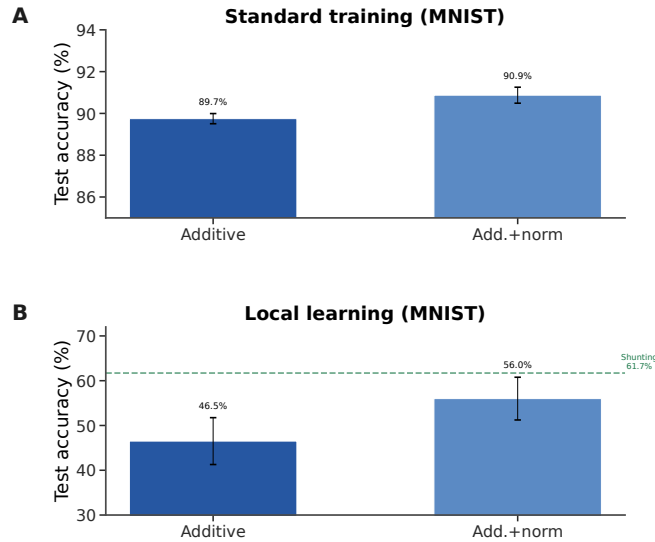


Figure S9: **Additive + normalization control (MNIST stress-regime diagnostic).** (A) Standard backprop: normalization provides a small boost (89.7% → 90.9%). (B) Local learning: normalization improves additive from 46.5% to 56.0% (+9.5 pp), partially closing the gap to shunting (61.7%, dashed green). These lower local accuracies come from a separate stress-regime diagnostic, not from the matched-capacity performance setting in Table S4.

A.13 Morphology × Inhibition Regime Map

This regime map (Fig. S10) tests whether tree geometry changes the inhibitory operating point at which shunting helps. It supports the claim that morphology changes the useful inhibition regime; a fuller mechanistic account would require matched theory diagnostics for every cell in the grid.

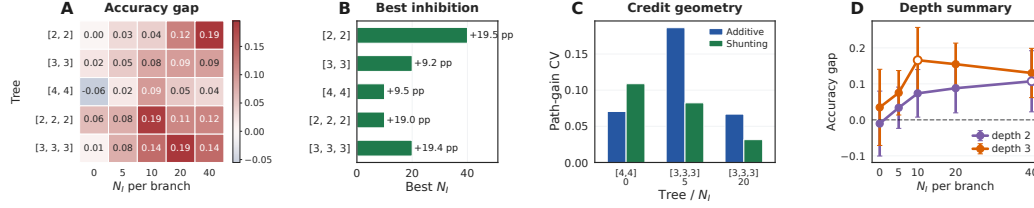


Figure S10: **Morphology shifts the useful inhibitory regime.** (A) Shunting-minus-additive LocalCA accuracy gap across dendritic morphologies and inhibitory synapse counts. (B) Best inhibitory count for each morphology. (C) Representative path-gain diagnostic for selected morphology cells, used to connect the performance map to credit geometry. (D) Average shunting advantage by depth, with markers showing the peak inhibitory count for each depth.

575 A.14 Input-Mode Probe: Direct Inhibitory Stream vs. Explicit Inhibitory Cells

576 The main experiments use input-driven inhibitory streams: the transfer layer provides nonnegative
577 excitatory and inhibitory channels from the external input, and excitatory dendrites receive learned
578 I-to-E conductance banks directly. To test whether the same mechanism can be generated by an
579 explicit feedforward inhibitory population, we ran a one-feedforward-layer noise-resilience probe
580 that preserves the relevant dendritic depth ([3, 3] morphology). In this setting, explicit inhibitory cells
581 reach $94.2 \pm 0.2\%$ under path-transport LocalCA when their dendrites use the same update policy as
582 excitatory dendrites, $93.8 \pm 0.2\%$ when those inhibitory-cell updates are frozen, and $95.1 \pm 0.3\%$
583 under standard backprop. Direct input-driven inhibition gives the expected broadcast-fidelity ladder
584 on the same one-layer architecture: per-soma feedback reaches $85.2 \pm 0.7\%$, while exact effective
585 path transport reaches $95.2 \pm 0.0\%$. Thus explicit inhibitory cells can generate useful path-gain
586 structure once the architecture isolates the dendritic-path question.

Inhibitory input mode	Training / broadcast	Test accuracy
Direct inhibitory stream	LocalCA, per-soma feedback	0.852 ± 0.007
Direct inhibitory stream	LocalCA, exact effective path transport	0.952 ± 0.000
Explicit I cells	LocalCA, path transport, train I-cell dendrites	0.942 ± 0.002
Explicit I cells	LocalCA, path transport, freeze I-cell dendrites	0.938 ± 0.002
Explicit I cells	standard backprop	0.951 ± 0.003

Table S6: **One-feedforward-layer input-mode path-gain probe on noise resilience (3 seeds).** All rows use one excitatory dendritic population with [3, 3] morphology and nonnegative inputs. The direct-stream rows have no explicit inhibitory neurons; the input stream drives learned branch-level inhibitory conductance banks directly. The explicit-I rows use a matched inhibitory population with [3, 3] morphology. Exact effective path transport closes the direct-stream per-soma gap, and explicit inhibitory cells nearly match both direct-stream path transport and the explicit-I matched backpropagation reference.

587 **Post-training inhibition intervention and exact-error rank.** We next tested whether learned
588 inhibitory conductance carries sample-dependent structure rather than only changing global scale
589 (Fig. S11). We replayed trained shunting LocalCA checkpoints while replacing the branch-level
590 inhibitory conductance with four post-training interventions: zero inhibition, sample-shuffled inhibition,
591 per-branch batch means, or one uniform matched mean. On a 512-example held-out subset,
592 learned MNIST inhibition at $N_I=5$ gives $90.4 \pm 1.1\%$ accuracy, while the four interventions drop
593 to 19.8–26.4%. On noise resilience at $N_I=10$, learned inhibition gives $80.5 \pm 2.4\%$, while the
594 interventions drop to 10.3–19.3%. Thus the inhibitory field is not interchangeable with a matched
595 global conductance load. We also computed the SVD of exact compartment-error matrices across
596 samples and compartments. At matched MNIST $N_I=5$, shunting has lower unrestricted rank-1
597 residual than additive (0.70 ± 0.21 vs. 0.81 ± 0.11), lower participation rank (5.7 ± 4.0 vs. 8.0 ± 3.7),
598 and higher actual per-soma broadcast cosine (0.74 ± 0.13 vs. 0.37 ± 0.18), supporting but not by
599 itself proving the path-gain compressibility interpretation.

Model implication	Biological prediction
Path-local inhibitory conductance changes α_n^{cond} only for descendants whose credit path crosses the inhibited compartment. The log derivative $\partial \log \alpha_n^{\text{cond}} / \partial G_k^I = -R_k^{\text{tot}}$ predicts stronger credit gating in high-resistance compartments. Single-channel broadcast succeeds when exact compartment errors are effectively shared across the relevant branches and fails when branch identity matters.	Branch-local inhibitory perturbation should distort plasticity or teaching-signal efficacy for synapses below the perturbed compartment more than for sister branches. The same inhibitory conductance change should have larger effects on low-conductance/high-resistance branches than on already high-conductance branches. Tasks requiring route- or context-specific branch credit should need richer dendritic teaching signals than a single scalar modulatory broadcast.

Table S7: **Experimental predictions from the path-gain mechanism.** These are qualitative biological predictions, not claims tested directly in this paper.

We also computed the direct log-gain covariance margin in Eq. (9) on the selected morphology diagnostic checkpoints. The margin is zero when no inhibitory conductance is present and slightly negative in the inhibited shunting selections (-2.5×10^{-3} , -5.0×10^{-4} , and -2.8×10^{-4} at $N_I=5, 20, 40$). We therefore do not use this covariance condition as a positive main result. Its role is to clarify when shunting should compress gains; the empirical claim rests on the measured comparative path-gain dispersion, exact-error rank, and inhibition-intervention diagnostics.

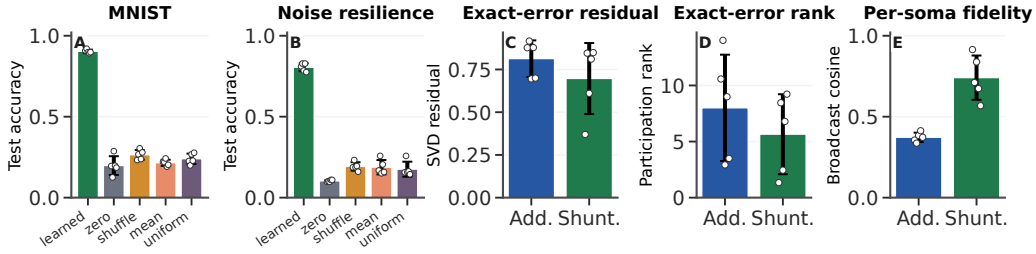


Figure S11: **Post-training inhibition intervention and exact-error compressibility.** (A,B) Post-training inhibitory-conductance interventions on trained shunting LocalCA checkpoints. Accuracy is measured on a 512-example held-out subset; dots show seeds. Removing, shuffling, or clamping learned inhibition collapses performance, showing that the learned inhibitory field is sample-dependent and functionally important. (C,D) Exact-error diagnostics on matched MNIST $N_I=5$ runs. Shunting has a smaller unrestricted rank-1 residual, lower participation rank, and higher actual per-soma broadcast cosine than additive, so the exact error field is both more intrinsically compressible and better aligned with the implemented feedback field. Error bars are s.d. across 5 seeds.

A.15 Experimental Predictions

The model is not a detailed cell-type circuit model, but its path-gain identity gives falsifiable dendritic predictions (Table S7). These predictions are naturally aligned with branch-level dendritic computation and compartment-targeted inhibition in pyramidal neurons [5–7, 13].

A.16 Cue-Routing Feedback-Rank Diagnostic

Cue routing tests a regime where one shared teaching signal is expected to fail: context determines which noisy cue is reliable, so different pathways should receive different credit. Figure S12 shows that the benchmark is learnable and that moving beyond the restricted per-soma / single-channel baselines helps, but the path-structured variant does not yet beat the best unstructured low-rank setting. We therefore interpret this result as a failure-mode and rank-requirement diagnostic, not as a solved structured-feedback method.

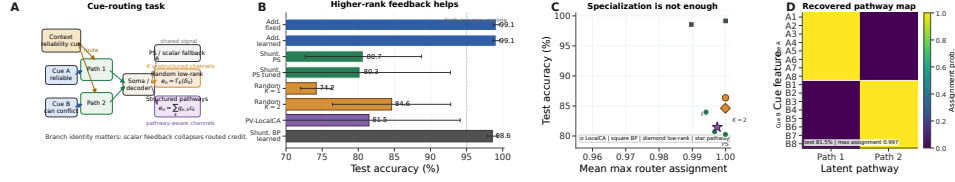


Figure S12: **Structured feedback when restricted feedback fails.** (A) Cue-routing task schematic. Context determines which noisy cue is reliable on each trial, so different dendritic pathways should receive different teaching signals. (B) Five-seed comparison of per-soma, random low-rank, and pathway-structured feedback. Moving beyond the per-soma / single-channel baselines helps, while the best structured repair remains open. (C) Test accuracy vs. router specialization across learned-router conditions. High specialization alone does not guarantee success. (D) Recovered pathway assignments for a representative learned-router run. Cue-A and cue-B features segregate into separate latent pathways even when feedback quality, rather than router discreteness, is the limiting factor.

A.17 Random Low-Rank Broadcast Channels

These controls test whether failures of the restricted per-soma baseline reflect insufficient feedback bandwidth rather than a failure of local eligibility itself.

Setting	Broadcast	Test accuracy
<i>Noise resilience, shunting, rank bridge</i>		
per-soma	per-soma feedback	0.662 ± 0.016
path propagation	recursive attenuation proxy	0.762 ± 0.047
low-rank	$K=1$	0.453 ± 0.126
low-rank	$K=2$	0.630 ± 0.042
low-rank	$K=4$	0.764 ± 0.025
low-rank	$K=8$	0.795 ± 0.019
path transport	exact effective path transport	0.847 ± 0.018
<i>Cue routing, learned shunting router, rank/structure sweep</i>		
per-soma	tuned per-soma feedback	0.803 ± 0.125
low-rank	$K=1$	0.742 ± 0.022
low-rank	$K=2$	0.846 ± 0.082
low-rank	$K=4$	0.748 ± 0.085
pathway-vector	tuned structured rank-2	0.815 ± 0.126

Table S8: **Rank bridge and rank-structure comparison.** On shunting noise resilience, both recursive path propagation and higher-rank random low-rank broadcast close a substantial fraction of the gap between per-soma feedback and exact effective path transport, with low-rank continuing to improve up to $K=8$. On cue routing, the learned-router sweep shows that moving beyond the per-soma baseline helps, but the best unstructured low-rank setting ($K=2$) is still slightly better than the tuned structured pathway-vector variant. We therefore interpret routed credit assignment as an open higher-rank problem rather than as a solved pathway-vector rescue.

B Dendritic Network Implementation

This section gives the implementation-level specification needed to reproduce the dendritic architectures and LocalCA updates. It separates the biological modeling assumptions from software choices such as positive raw-parameter transforms, decoder-error coordinates, and optimizer gradient assignment.

B.1 Implementation Overview

Each feedforward dendritic layer is a population of dendritic neurons. A neuron contains a rooted tree of compartments; each compartment has an excitatory synapse bank, optionally an inhibitory synapse bank, and dendritic coupling conductances from its children. The main experiments use branch-level input-driven inhibition: a nonnegative transfer stage produces excitatory and inhibitory

input streams from the external input, and the inhibitory stream drives learned I-to-E conductance banks on excitatory dendritic branches. The explicit-I probe in Table S6 instead instantiates a separate feedforward inhibitory population, whose output projects inhibitory conductance onto excitatory dendrites.

The additive and shunting cores are architecture-matched: they use the same tree, synapse counts, nonnegative transfer stage, positive conductance parameterization, optimizer protocol, and seed sets. They differ only in how a branch combines excitatory, inhibitory, and dendritic inputs. Decoder weights are unconstrained readout parameters and are not interpreted as conductances. Table S9 maps each implementation concept to its governing equation, code location, and update scope.

Concept / parameter family	Paper eq.	Code location	Update scope / notes
Shunting branch voltage	Eq. (1)	<code>DendriticBranchLayer.forward (use_shunting=True)</code>	Numerator/denominator conductance integration; in-theorem.
Additive control voltage	Eq. (1)	<code>DendriticBranchLayer.forward (use_shunting=False); normalize_additive_voltage</code>	Same tree/synapses; inhibition subtractive rather than a denominator load.
E/I synaptic and dendritic-coupling conductances	Cor. 1; Eqs. (13)–(14)	<code>LocalCreditAssignment._apply_local_rule_gradients</code> (conductance branch)	LocalCA eligibility $xR^{\text{tot}}(E-V)e$, then positive-transform derivative; covered by the theorem.
Additive eligibility (matched control)	Eq. (13)	<code>_apply_local_rule_gradients</code> (additive branch)	Matched signed additive derivative, with optional additive-gain controls.
Broadcast-mode switch	broadcast e_n	<code>LocalRuleConfig.error_broadcast_mode; _compute_low_rank_broadcast; _precompute_path_transport_errors; _precompute_path_propagation_factors</code>	Selects scalar/per-soma, low-rank, path-transport, or pathway-vector feedback; bandwidth-ladder controls.
4F / 5F reliability gates	r_n^{4F}, ϕ_n	<code>_compute_layer_rho, _compute_layer_phi*, clamp_phi, FiveFactorConfig</code>	Slow bounded preconditioners, not additional task-error channels; outside the theorem.
Reactivation transfer	$f_n(V)$	configured local/autograd schedule	Post-voltage activation derivative; implementation-level training component.
Top- k synapse banks	—	<code>masked_apply_local_rule_gradients</code>	Sparse input selection; masks multiply the branch eligibility.
Linear / nonlinear decoder	$\delta_0^a = W_{\text{dec}}^T \delta^y / J_{\text{dec}}^T \delta^y$	local decoder gradient or autograd	Maps output error into soma/core coordinates; implementation-level.
HSIC auxiliary	—	auxiliary gradient on selected representations	Batch dependence regularizer; auxiliary objective, not a local theorem term.
Router / pathway roles	pathway-vector	configuration-dependent router/pathway updates	Exploratory higher-rank routing; outside the theorem.
Experiment knobs	—	<code>LocalRuleConfig</code> YAML (<code>rule_variant, error_broadcast_mode, broadcast_rank, five_factor</code>)	Reproduces rule family, feedback bandwidth, and 5F stabilizer settings.

Table S9: Implementation map: concepts, equations, code, and update scope. The exact factorization (Cor. 1) covers conductance-stage branch and dendritic-coupling parameters; decoder, reactivation, top- k , HSIC, and router mechanisms are implementation-level training components documented alongside the theorem rather than derived from it. Code anchors are symbolic names so that minor refactors do not invalidate the map.

Implementation-specific update paths. Top- k synapse-bank scores are learned selection parameters; the selected masks gate active presynaptic drives and the corresponding local gradients, while inactive weights receive no LocalCA update unless an explicit inactive-update control is enabled. The discrete selection itself is treated as an implementation-level sparsity mechanism rather than as a conductance variable in the theorem. Reactivation slope and bias parameters use the configured optimizer schedule; the conductance update still uses the local derivative $f'_n(V_n)$ for voltage-error conversion. Router/pathway parameters in the cue-routing controls are trained through their configured router/pathway objective and are not included in the conductance-factorization theorem. HSIC gradients are applied to selected representation tensors through the configured local-learning representation pathway; they do not replace the LocalCA conductance eligibility and are reported as an auxiliary objective.

650 B.2 Morphology and Synapse Banks

651 The morphology notation $[b_1, b_2, \dots, b_D]$ specifies a rooted dendritic tree. The factor b_d is the fan-in
 652 from dendritic stage d to the next more proximal stage. Thus $[3, 3]$ gives 3 proximal branches per
 653 soma and 3 distal branches per proximal branch, for 9 distal leaves per soma. In the main feedforward
 654 models, synaptic inputs terminate on dendritic branches rather than directly on the soma. Unless a
 655 control explicitly changes this, each branch has N_E excitatory synapses and N_I inhibitory synapses.
 656 The branch input is sparse through a learned top- k or banked synapse selection module; inactive
 657 synapses are masked out in the local update unless the corresponding control enables inactive-weight
 658 updates.

659 For a branch n , write $x_{nj}^E, x_{nj}^I \geq 0$ for the selected excitatory and inhibitory presynaptic drives and
 660 a_c for the post-activation activity of child compartment c . The branch-level excitatory, inhibitory,
 661 and dendritic conductance currents are

$$U_n^E = \sum_{j=1}^{N_E} g_{nj}^E x_{nj}^E, \quad U_n^I = \sum_{j=1}^{N_I} g_{nj}^I x_{nj}^I, \quad D_n = \sum_{c \in \text{child}(n)} g_{c \rightarrow n}^{\text{den}} a_c.$$

662 The corresponding dendritic coupling load is

$$G_n^{\text{den}} = \sum_{c \in \text{child}(n)} g_{c \rightarrow n}^{\text{den}}.$$

663 For leaf branches, $D_n = G_n^{\text{den}} = 0$. For direct input-driven inhibition, x^I is produced by the
 664 inhibitory transfer stream. For explicit-I controls, x^I is the activity of the inhibitory-cell population.

665 B.3 Shunting and Additive Forward Equations

666 In the shunting core, excitatory reversal is 1, leak and inhibitory reversal are 0, and leak conductance
 667 is fixed to 1. The implemented branch voltage is therefore

$$V_n^{\text{shunt}} = \frac{U_n^E + D_n}{1 + U_n^E + U_n^I + G_n^{\text{den}} + \varepsilon}.$$

668 The small numerical ε is used only for floating-point safety; analytically the leak conductance keeps
 669 the denominator positive. In implementation equations, the same stabilized denominator is used for
 670 the recorded input resistance:

$$g_n^{\text{tot}} = 1 + U_n^E + U_n^I + G_n^{\text{den}}, \quad g_{n,\varepsilon}^{\text{tot}} = g_n^{\text{tot}} + \varepsilon, \quad R_{n,\varepsilon}^{\text{tot}} = (g_{n,\varepsilon}^{\text{tot}})^{-1}.$$

671 The main analytical equations write $R_n^{\text{tot}} = (g_n^{\text{tot}})^{-1}$; exact-gradient reconstruction tests use the
 672 implementation convention above. In the additive control, inhibition is subtractive rather than
 673 shunting. With the same nonnegative conductance variables and nonnegative inputs, the implemented
 674 comparator is

$$V_n^{\text{add}} = U_n^E + D_n - U_n^I,$$

675 with optional additive-normalization controls reported separately in Fig. S9. Thus additive inhibition
 676 changes the signed voltage contribution and local additive eligibility, but it does not enter the
 677 denominator and does not gate conductance-stage path gain through R_n^{tot} ; Table S10 summarizes the
 678 matched comparison.

Property	Shunting / conductance core	Additive control
Voltage	Normalized by total conductance	Signed E/I voltage sum
Inhibition	Divisive conductance load	Subtractive signed term
Synaptic eligibility	$x R^{\text{tot}} (E - V) e$	$s x e, s \in \{+1, -1\}$
Driving force	Present through $E - V$	Absent from additive derivative
Input resistance	State-dependent, $R^{\text{tot}} = (g^{\text{tot}})^{-1}$	Effectively fixed
Credit interpretation	Inhibition changes path gain and voltage sensitivity	Inhibition shifts voltage but does not gate path gain

Table S10: **Matched shunting/additive comparison.** Both architectures use their own local derivative, so the comparison changes the forward-pass integration rule rather than applying a shunting-derived update to an additive model.

679 B.4 Positive Parameterization and Raw-Parameter Gradients

680 Trainable synaptic and dendritic conductances are stored as unconstrained raw parameters θ and
 681 transformed by a positive map $g = \psi(\theta)$, with `softplus` used in the main reported runs:

$$\psi(\theta) = \log(1 + \exp \theta), \quad \psi'(\theta) = \sigma(\theta).$$

682 Equations in the main text give conductance-space gradients $\partial L / \partial g$. Before assigning gradients to
 683 the optimizer variables, the implementation applies the chain rule

$$\frac{\partial L}{\partial \theta} = \frac{\partial L}{\partial g} \psi'(\theta).$$

684 The exact-gradient reconstruction diagnostic includes this parameterization factor, as well as top- k
 685 activity masks and dendritic block-linear parameterization. This is why the reconstruction comparison
 686 is against raw autograd gradients rather than only against abstract conductance variables.

687 B.5 Post-Voltage Reactivation

688 The conductance stage produces a pre-reactivation voltage V_n , after which each branch may transmit a
 689 monotone post-voltage activity $a_n = f_n(V_n)$. The main sweeps use the learnable bounded transform

$$f_n(V) = \frac{\tanh(m_n(V - b_n)) + 1}{2}, \quad m_n = \exp(\ell_{m,n}),$$

690 with derivative

$$f'_n(V) = \frac{m_n}{2} [1 - \tanh^2(m_n(V - b_n))].$$

691 When reactivation is enabled, exact path transport uses the effective gain $\tilde{\alpha}_n$: parent-to-child transport
 692 includes the parent activation derivative, and the local update converts activation-space error into
 693 pre-reactivation voltage error by multiplying by the child derivative. With identity transfer, this
 694 reduces to conductance-stage transport through α_n^{cond} .

695 B.6 Decoder and Error Coordinates

696 Let h denote the final soma/core activity passed to the decoder and let $\delta^y = \partial L / \partial \hat{y}$. For a linear
 697 decoder $\hat{y} = W_{\text{dec}} h$, the soma/core activation-space teaching error is

$$\delta_0^a = W_{\text{dec}}^\top \delta^y.$$

698 For a nonlinear decoder, used in the CIFAR-10 compact control ladder, the implementation uses the
 699 decoder-input Jacobian product

$$\delta_0^a = J_{\text{dec}}(h)^\top \delta^y.$$

700 All LocalCA broadcast modes are defined in this soma/core activation-error coordinate system before
 701 local conversion to voltage-space errors. Decoder-update modes are: **backprop**, which uses autograd
 702 for decoder parameters; **local**, which is implemented for the linear readout and assigns

$$\hat{\nabla}_{W_{\text{dec}}} L = \langle \delta^y h^\top \rangle_B, \quad \hat{\nabla}_{b_{\text{dec}}} L = \langle \delta^y \rangle_B;$$

703 and **frozen**, which holds the decoder fixed. The local decoder gradient is output-space; δ_0^a is the
 704 mapped soma/core activation-space error used by dendritic broadcasts.

705 B.7 Biological Plausibility Assumptions

706 The model makes the following explicit assumptions. First, it uses the steady-state solution of
 707 the passive cable equation rather than temporal membrane dynamics; all path gains and gradient
 708 diagnostics refer to conductance-stage voltages at steady state. Second, each dendritic cell is a rooted
 709 tree, so each compartment has a unique path to the soma and the closed-form path gains α_n^{cond}
 710 and $\tilde{\alpha}_n$ are well-defined. Third, synaptic and dendritic conductance parameters are nonnegative by
 711 construction. Fourth, the main sweeps enforce nonnegative first-layer presynaptic drive through
 712 nonnegative inputs or a ReLU transfer stage. Fifth, post-voltage reactivation is handled through
 713 local $f'(V)$ factors along the path. Sixth, each dendritic synapse receives a restricted non-local
 714 feedback field-scalar, per-soma, low-rank, path-structured, or transported-oracle depending on the
 715 condition-while presynaptic activity, voltage, reversal potential, input resistance, and slowly estimated
 716 branch-level modulators are local or branch-local quantities.

Quantity	Symbol	Convention
Voltage	V	Conductance-stage shunting voltage in $[0, 1]$ under nonnegative drive; additive controls may be signed
Conductances	$g^{\text{syn}}, g^{\text{den}}$	Nonnegative via $g = \text{softplus}(\theta)$; local gradients are mapped to raw θ by the transform derivative
Leak conductance	g^{leak}	Set to 1
Input resistance	R^{tot}	≤ 1

Table S11: Units and normalization.

717 B.8 Units and Parameterization

718 Table S11 summarizes the numerical conventions used throughout the implementation and diagnostics,
719 including which quantities are constrained conductances and which are unconstrained readout
720 parameters.

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721 B.9 Representative Manuscript Architectures

Setting	Encoder	E layers	Tree	Synapses / branch	Seeds	Notes
Gradient fidelity / path-gain / noise-resilience mechanism	id.+ReLU	[128, 128]	[3, 3]	$N_E=40, N_I \in \{0, 5, 10, 20, 40\}$	5 fidelity, 5 oracle	Main mechanism sweeps in Figs. 2 and 3; reactivation <code>param_tanh</code> .
MNIST / figure-ground local performance	id.+ReLU	[128]	[3, 3]	$N_E=40, N_I=20$	5	Best local 5F per-soma runs in Table S4; reactivation <code>param_tanh</code> .
Fashion-MNIST performance	id.+ReLU	[128]	[3, 3]	$N_E=40, N_I=20$	5	Dedicated five-seed standard-vs-local performance sweep; reactivation <code>param_tanh</code> .
Cue-routing PV-LocalCA	router	[64]	[2]	$N_E=10, N_I=4$	5	Learned router with two pathway groups and rank-2 structured feedback; reactivation <code>param_tanh</code> .
CIFAR-10 compact direct-I-stream control ladder	id.+ReLU	[20] E, no I cells	[3, 3, 3, 3]	$N_E=25, N_I=25$ direct I-to-E, with matched no-I controls	5 per condition	Harder-dataset stress test with input-driven inhibitory conductance, decoder [32, 16], decoder-aware soma mapping, and additive fairness controls.
Morphology $\times$ inhibition appendix map	id.+ReLU	[128, 128]	[2, 2], [3, 3], [4, 4], [2, 2, 2], [3, 3, 3]	$N_E=40, N_I \in \{0, 5, 10, 20, 40\}$	3	Supportive 3-seed sweep; reactivation <code>param_tanh</code> .

Table S12: **Representative architectures used in the manuscript.** All dendritic rows use explicit branch-level excitatory and inhibitory synapse banks without direct somatic synapses, nonnegative conductances, and a nonnegative first-layer drive enforced by an explicit ReLU transfer stage in the main runs. The tree column gives dendritic morphology per excitatory neuron, and the synapse counts report excitatory and inhibitory synapses per branch.

722 B.10 Hyperparameters

723 Table S13 collects the core training hyperparameters for each main experiment. Learning rates are
724 applied through parameter groups (top- k , dendritic block-linear, reactivation, decoder) with the values
725 given in the representative config files; where a single LR is reported, every group uses that value.

Setting	Opt.	LR	Batch	Epochs	Weight decay	Notes
MNIST / Fashion-MNIST / figure-ground MNIST (5F per-soma LocalCA)	Adam	$10^{-3} / 5 \cdot 10^{-4}$ (block / react.)	256	100	0	fixed-epoch, no early stopping; <code>param_tanh</code> reactivation
MNIST / Fashion-MNIST / figure-ground MNIST (matched backprop reference)	Adam	$10^{-3} / 5 \cdot 10^{-4}$	256	100	0	matched to LocalCA setup
Gradient fidelity / path-gain / noise resilience	Adam	10^{-3}	256	50	0	5 seeds, hooks enabled for diagnostic capture
Morphology $\times$ inhibition regime map (supportive)	Adam	10^{-3}	256	50	0	3 seeds
Cue routing	Adam	10^{-3}	256	90	0	early stopping with patience 30
CIFAR-10 compact direct-I-stream depth-4 LocalCA	Adam	$10^{-3} / 10^{-4}$ (block / react.)	256	400	0 / 0.01	grad-clip 5.0, early stop patience 50, nonlinear decoder
CIFAR-10 compact direct-I-stream depth-4 BP	Adam	10^{-3}	256	200	0.01	early stop patience 40, matched backpropagation reference

Table S13: **Training hyperparameters by experiment.** All runs use Adam with default $\beta_1=0.9$, $\beta_2=0.999$, $\varepsilon=10^{-8}$. Reactivation and block-linear parameter groups use a slower LR to keep conductance-level dynamics stable. Representative configs are provided in the accompanying repository.

726 B.11 Effective Broadcast Dimensionality in Main Architectures

727 Table S14 reports the effective feedback dimensionality of each main architecture.

Setting	Soma/core dim.	Output classes	Main feedback field
Gradient fidelity / path-gain / noise resilience	128, 128	10	Per-soma soma/core error at matched-width dendritic layers
MNIST / Fashion-MNIST performance	128	10	Per-soma soma/core error
Figure-ground MNIST performance	128	10	Per-soma soma/core error
Cue routing	64	2	Tuned per-soma baseline; higher-rank tests use low-rank or pathway-vector feedback
Compact CIFAR-10 harder-dataset stress test	20	10	Vector-valued per-soma after decoder-aware mapping; higher-rank tests use explicit low-rank or path transport

Table S14: **Effective dimensionality of the main feedback in the reported architectures.** Output loss gradients are first mapped into decoder-input/soma coordinates. The main performance and mechanism runs use the implemented `per_soma` mode when the soma/core dimension matches layer width; scalar, low-rank, pathway-vector, and transported-error conditions are labeled separately as controls or oracles.

728 B.12 Compute Resources

729 All experiments were run on an institutional GPU cluster. Reproduction runs use one NVIDIA A100
 730 or H100-class GPU (40–80GB memory) per seed and do not require distributed training. Table S15
 731 gives approximate single-GPU runtime ranges for the reported experiment families; unreported
 732 exploratory runs used additional cluster time and are not counted in the reproduction estimate.

Experiment family	Runs	Time / run	Approx. GPU-h
Performance and verification	~25	5–20 min	4–9
Gradient, path-gain, inhibition, and oracle diagnostics	~80	10–30 min	15–40
Morphology, stress, rule, and feedback controls	~120	5–35 min	20–70
CIFAR-10 control ladder	70	0.8–2.5 h	60–175
Figure generation and CPU-side summaries	–	< 5 h total	< 5

Table S15: **Approximate compute for reported results.** Ranges reflect single-seed wall-clock variation across A100/H100-class GPUs, data-loading overhead, and early stopping.

733 B.13 Code, Data, and Asset Availability

734 MNIST, Fashion-MNIST, and CIFAR-10 are public datasets or public benchmark assets cited in the
 735 paper; we use them under their standard published access conditions and cite their original sources
 736 in the bibliography. The accompanying source package contains the core model, training code,
 737 diagnostic utilities, representative configuration files, tests, figure-source summaries, and analysis
 738 entry points. Code will be released publicly at the time of arXiv posting with an immutable tag. The
 739 paper does not release a new dataset or a stand-alone pretrained model asset. Dataset access pages are
 740 the original MNIST site / UCI entry ([https://archive.ics.uci.edu/dataset/683/mnist+](https://archive.ics.uci.edu/dataset/683/mnist+database+of+handwritten+digits)
 741 [database+of+handwritten+digits](https://archive.ics.uci.edu/dataset/683/mnist+database+of+handwritten+digits)), the Fashion-MNIST repository (<https://github.com/zalando-research/fashion-mnist>), and the CIFAR page ([https://www.cs.toronto.edu/](https://www.cs.toronto.edu/~kriz/cifar.html)
 742 [~kriz/cifar.html](https://www.cs.toronto.edu/~kriz/cifar.html)).

Asset	Use in this paper	Access / license or terms note
MNIST	Digit classification and derived nonnegative synthetic tasks	Public benchmark from the original MNIST site / UCI entry; UCI lists DOI 10.24432/C53K8Q and asks users to follow the original acknowledgement policy; no raw-data redistribution.
Fashion-MNIST	Apparel classification stress test	Public Zalando Research benchmark; repository is MIT licensed; no raw-data redistribution beyond standard dataset loaders.
CIFAR-10	Flattened harder-dataset stress test	Public CIFAR dataset site asks users to cite Krizhevsky’s technical report; no raw-data redistribution.
Synthetic tasks	Figure-ground MNIST, noise resilience, cue integration	Generated procedurally from public benchmarks or random seeds described in Appendix D; no new third-party asset is introduced.

Table S16: **Existing assets used in the manuscript.** We credit the original sources in the bibliography, use public benchmark assets under their published access conditions, and do not redistribute third-party raw data in the manuscript package.

744 B.14 LocalCA Broadcast and Gradient Assignment

745 LocalCA first maps the output loss derivative to the soma/core activation-space error δ_0^a and then
746 constructs a branch voltage-error field. In the final dendritic layer this is the decoder-input error; in
747 earlier matched-width layers the practical implementation reuses the same coordinate by neuron index
748 as an approximate layer-soma teaching signal. This is an inter-layer feedback approximation, separate
749 from the within-tree path-transport approximation studied by the main theory. In the main reported
750 per_soma mode, if the layer width matches the soma/core error dimension, each soma-specific error
751 component is broadcast to the corresponding dendritic compartments:

$$e_{n,b}^a = \delta_{0,b}^a \in \mathbb{R}^{d_0}.$$

752 The stricter scalar control compresses the soma/core error to one value per example,

$$\bar{\delta}_b = \frac{1}{d_0} \sum_{c=1}^{d_0} \delta_{0,bc}^a, \quad e_{n,b}^a = \bar{\delta}_b \mathbf{1}_n,$$

753 where d_0 is the dimension of the soma/core error. If dimensions do not match, the implementation
754 falls back to scalar-style expansion rather than silently inventing an unmatched per-soma map. The
755 low-rank controls use fixed random projection and mixing matrices P_K and Q_n ,

$$c_b = P_K \delta_{0,b}^a \in \mathbb{R}^K, \quad e_{n,b}^a = Q_n c_b.$$

756 The pathway-vector controls use router-inferred pathway roles to gate and transport a low-rank
757 role vector. The transported oracle uses the effective tree recursion. If p is the parent of child c ,
758 activation-space error is propagated by

$$e_c^a = e_p^a f'_p(V_p) R_{p,\varepsilon}^{\text{tot}} g_{c \rightarrow p}^{\text{den}},$$

759 and the local pre-reactivation voltage error used in conductance eligibility is

$$e_n^V = \begin{cases} e_n^a f'_n(V_n), & \text{post-voltage reactivation enabled,} \\ e_n^a, & \text{identity transfer.} \end{cases}$$

760 This operational definition is the implementation counterpart of the effective path gain $\tilde{\alpha}_n$ in Theo-
761 rem 1.

762 For shunting branches, the conductance-space LocalCA gradients assigned before raw-parameter
763 transformation are

$$\hat{\nabla}_{g_{nj}^E} L = \langle e_n^V x_{nj}^E R_{n,\varepsilon}^{\text{tot}} (1 - V_n) \rangle_B, \quad \hat{\nabla}_{g_{nj}^I} L = \langle e_n^V x_{nj}^I R_{n,\varepsilon}^{\text{tot}} (0 - V_n) \rangle_B,$$

764 and for a dendritic coupling from child c to parent n ,

$$\widehat{\nabla}_{g_{c \rightarrow n}^{\text{den}}} L = \langle e_n^V R_{n,\varepsilon}^{\text{tot}}(a_c - V_n) \rangle_B.$$

765 For additive controls, the matching local derivatives are

$$\widehat{\nabla}_{g_{nj}^E} L = \langle e_n^V x_{nj}^E \rangle_B, \quad \widehat{\nabla}_{g_{nj}^I} L = -\langle e_n^V x_{nj}^I \rangle_B, \quad \widehat{\nabla}_{g_{c \rightarrow n}^{\text{den}}} L = \langle e_n^V a_c \rangle_B.$$

766 The optimizer applies the usual descent step; equivalently, the sign can be absorbed into the definition
 767 of the broadcast error. After these conductance-space gradients are formed, they are multiplied by
 768 the positive-transform derivative $\psi'(\theta)$ and by any active synapse masks before assignment to raw
 769 parameters.

770 B.15 4F and 5F Local Modulators

771 The 3F rule uses only the local eligibility and broadcast error above. The 4F and 5F variants
 772 multiply the conductance-space gradient by branch-level reliability factors before raw-parameter
 773 transformation. For 4F, the implementation records V_n from each branch layer and the corresponding
 774 soma/core activity V_0 . For each batch item b , it first averages over the non-batch coordinates of the
 775 recorded layer tensor to obtain scalar summaries $\bar{V}_{n,b}$ and $\bar{V}_{0,b}$. It then estimates covariance over the
 776 batch axis and smooths the resulting scalar with an EMA:

$$r_n^{4F} = \frac{\text{Cov}_B(\bar{V}_{n,b}, \bar{V}_{0,b})}{\sqrt{\text{Var}_B(\bar{V}_{n,b}) \text{Var}_B(\bar{V}_{0,b})} + \varepsilon}.$$

777 The EMA is initialized from the first observed batch statistic; the recorded tensors are detached
 778 from autograd, and the same mini-batch supplies both the statistics and the gradient update. This
 779 proxy is clamped to the positive stability range $[0.1, 2.0]$ before it multiplies the local gradient; sign-
 780 opposed covariance therefore reduces the multiplier rather than reversing update direction. Because
 781 the smoothed numerator and denominator can be updated separately, and because single-sample
 782 fallbacks use online covariance moments, the clamped value can exceed one and should be read as
 783 a preconditioner rather than a literal Pearson correlation. Single-sample online fallbacks for these
 784 statistics use Welford’s algorithm [25]. The 5F factor adds a bounded branch-level preconditioner
 785 based on how much branch voltage variance remains predictable from parent or soma-level activity:

$$\phi_n = \text{clip}_{[0.25, 4.0]} \left(\frac{\text{Var}(V_n)}{\sigma_{\text{res},n}^2 + \varepsilon} \right),$$

786 where $\sigma_{\text{res},n}^2$ is estimated online from a scalar ridge regression of the branch-layer voltage on the
 787 configured parent proxy. Batch-mode estimates center over examples and flatten remaining layer
 788 coordinates before updating the smoothed variance and covariance moments; single-sample fallback
 789 uses scalar online moments. Since these moments are smoothed and clamped rather than recomputed
 790 as a single ordinary least-squares fit on a fixed batch, ϕ_n can transiently fall below one or rise above
 791 one. The lower clamp keeps noisy residual estimates from suppressing a branch-layer update entirely,
 792 and the upper clamp prevents highly predictable branches from dominating optimization. In the main
 793 5F runs, the multiplier is $r_n^{4F} \phi_n$. The 5F sensitivity diagnostic in Fig. S2 varies the clamp and EMA
 794 rate to verify that the reported MNIST performance is not a single brittle clamp setting. By default
 795 the reliability statistics use EMA rate $\alpha_{\text{EMA}} = 0.1$ and a conditional-EMA residual estimator with
 796 ridge $\lambda_{\text{ridge}} = 10^{-3}$ for $\sigma_{\text{res},n}^2$, and all gate denominators use the stabilizer $\varepsilon = 10^{-8}$.

797 B.16 Algorithm

798 Algorithm 1 gives the update order for the main 5F per-soma LocalCA condition and shows where
 799 scalar, higher-bandwidth, and transported-error controls enter.

Algorithm 1 Main 5F Per-Soma LocalCA Update

```
1: Input: Dendritic model, batch  $(x, y)$ , optimizer
2: Forward pass; loss  $L$ , output error  $\delta^y$ 
3: Somatic/core activation error  $\delta_0^a = \text{decoder-input Jacobian product } J_{\text{dec}}(h_{\text{core}})^\top \delta^y$  (or  $W_{\text{dec}}^\top \delta^y$  for a linear decoder)
4: for each layer  $n$  (reverse) do
5:   Per-soma feedback  $e_n^a = \delta_0^a$  when dimensions match; scalar/low-rank/path controls replace this line
6:   Update EMA estimates for  $r_n^{4F}$  and  $\phi_n$  from batch voltages
7:   Convert to pre-reactivation voltage error  $e_n^V$  using the local activation derivative when needed
8:    $\widehat{\nabla}_{g_j^{\text{syn}}} L \leftarrow r_n^{4F} \phi_n \langle x_j R_{n,\varepsilon}^{\text{tot}} (E_j - V_n) e_n^V \rangle_B$ 
9:    $\widehat{\nabla}_{g_{c \rightarrow n}^{\text{den}}} L \leftarrow r_n^{4F} \phi_n \langle R_{n,\varepsilon}^{\text{tot}} (a_c - V_n) e_n^V \rangle_B$ 
10:  Map conductance gradients to raw parameters by multiplying by  $\partial g / \partial \theta$ 
11: end for
12: Optional controls replace line 5 with scalar, rank- $K$ , path-structured, or transported-oracle feedback.
13: Clip gradients; optimizer step
```

C Theoretical Details

This section collects theory-adjacent material that supports implementation and interpretation but is not part of the main proof. The central derivation remains Theorem 1, Corollary 1, and Prop. 2.

C.1 Random-Broadcast Alignment Intuition

Feedback-alignment arguments suggest that random or low-rank feedback can be useful when the induced local update remains positively correlated with the exact gradient [14]. In this model, that correlation depends on how local eligibility factors co-vary with the conductance-stage path gain in Eq. (4). We treat this as intuition only. The central theoretical object in the paper is still the exact pre-reactivation compartment error $\partial L / \partial V_n$; under identity upward transfer this reduces to $\alpha_n^{\text{cond}} \delta_0^V$, while post-voltage activation uses $\tilde{\alpha}_n \delta_0^V$. The empirical question is how faithfully different broadcast fields approximate that quantity.

C.2 Morphology-Aware Extensions

The following variants are implemented controls or architectural extensions used to test whether coarse morphology-aware feedback can approximate exact path transport. They are not required for the main 5F per-soma results, but they define the path-propagation, depth, normalization, and pathway-vector controls reported in the appendix figures and tables.

Path-integrated propagation. Modulate broadcast error by $\pi_n = \pi_{n-1} \cdot R_{n-1}^{\text{tot}} \cdot \bar{g}_{n-1}^{\text{den}}$, approximating depth attenuation from Eq. (4) without computing the exact sample-specific path gain.

Depth modulation. Per-branch scaling $\kappa_j = \kappa_{\text{base}} / (d_j + d_0)$, mirroring cable attenuation and testing whether a simple depth prior can stabilize distal updates.

Dendritic normalization. $\Delta g_j^{\text{den}} \leftarrow \Delta g_j^{\text{den}} / (\sum_k g_k^{\text{den}} + \varepsilon)$, analogous to homeostatic scaling [26] and used as an additive-control normalization comparison.

Pathway-vector feedback. For tasks with latent pathway structure, the broadcast becomes a role vector inferred from the router. Local pathway activity gates this vector. Upward block transport then passes it to earlier branches, aligning their feedback with downstream descendants.

Router-derived branch roles. Each branch receives a role profile inferred from router assignments and incoming block weights rather than from a hand-coded apical/basal label. Plasticity is then modulated by branch selectivity and a synapse-specific role-alignment factor, emphasizing pathway-consistent updates without imposing a heuristic branch taxonomy.

829 C.3 HSIC Auxiliary Objectives

830 Following [24], the figure-ground MNIST LocalCA runs optionally apply an HSIC-style auxiliary
831 gradient to selected layer representations Z :

$$\mathcal{L}^{\text{self}} = B^{-2} \text{tr}(\mathbf{K}_Z \mathbf{H} \mathbf{K}_Z \mathbf{H}), \quad \mathcal{L}^{\text{target}} = -B^{-2} \text{tr}(\mathbf{K}_Z \mathbf{H} \mathbf{K}_Y \mathbf{H}).$$

832 Here B is batch size, $\mathbf{H}$ is the centering matrix, $\mathbf{K}_Z$ uses the configured representation kernel, and
833 $\mathbf{K}_Y$ uses one-hot class labels when `target_source=labels`. The reported figure-ground runs
834 use an RBF kernel with fixed bandwidth $\sigma = 1.0$, HSIC weight 0.01, self and target weights 0.3,
835 five-epoch warmup, and gradient clipping at 0.1; the code applies the resulting auxiliary gradient
836 through the configured local-learning representation pathway rather than through the conductance-
837 factorization theorem. Moderate weights (0.01–0.1) help on figure-ground MNIST; negligible on
838 MNIST.

839 D Task Construction and Robustness Protocols

840 This section specifies the benchmark, synthetic-task, depth, and feedback-noise protocols used in the
841 experiments, with emphasis on which inputs preserve the nonnegative-drive regime assumed by the
842 conductance model.

843 D.1 General Data Handling

844 MNIST, Fashion-MNIST, and CIFAR-10 are loaded from standard public dataset loaders, flattened
845 before entering the dendritic core, scaled to $[0, 1]$, and passed through the configured nonnegative
846 transfer stage in the main experiments. MNIST-derived synthetic tasks preserve the flattened 28×28
847 geometry. Fixed random seeds define task generators such as corruption projections and context
848 masks; generator parameters are shared across train, validation, and test splits, while sample-level
849 corruptions are drawn per example. Validation accuracy selects checkpoints, and test accuracy is
850 reported. CIFAR-10 is used as a flattened harder-dataset stress test under the same conductance
851 constraints rather than as a competitive vision benchmark; no data augmentation is used as a
852 performance device.

853 D.2 Supervised Benchmark Tasks

854 **MNIST and Fashion-MNIST.** These ten-class tasks use nonnegative pixel inputs. MNIST tests
855 whether per-soma 5F LocalCA approaches matched backpropagation on clean supervised data;
856 Fashion-MNIST adds a same-dimensional distribution shift.

857 **CIFAR-10 harder-dataset stress test.** CIFAR-10 inputs are flattened RGB images in $[0, 1]$. The
858 compact CIFAR family uses a smaller dendritic core, nonlinear decoder, and decoder-aware LocalCA
859 mapping to test whether the broadcast-fidelity ladder persists on harder data: per-soma feedback is
860 weak, higher-rank feedback helps, and exact effective path transport approaches the matched shunting
861 backpropagation reference.

862 **Figure-ground MNIST.** For each reshaped 28×28 MNIST image, the right half carries the digit
863 and the left half is replaced by independent distractors $u_{r,c} \sim \text{Uniform}(0, 0.25)$, clipped to $[0, 1]$
864 when needed. The task tests whether local credit assignment exploits spatial signal/distractor structure
865 without leaving the nonnegative-drive regime. The main LocalCA performance rows use the HSIC
866 auxiliary objective with weight 0.01, which adds roughly 3 pp in the ablation; the matched shunting
867 BP reference in Table S4 is the standard cross-entropy reference.

868 **Noise resilience.** Flattened MNIST images are corrupted as $\tilde{x} = \text{clip}(x + \sigma_{\text{task}} A z, 0, 1)$ with
869 $\sigma_{\text{task}} = 1.5$, a fixed task-seeded projection $A \in \mathbb{R}^{784 \times 50}$, and fresh $z \sim \mathcal{N}(0, I_{50})$ for each
870 corrupted example. The fixed projection creates correlated interference without reducing the task to
871 memorizing one corruption pattern.

872 **Cue integration.** Two noisy cue streams (A and B) are presented simultaneously for two-class
873 classification, with a one-hot context indicating which cue is reliable on each trial. Cue vectors are

clipped to $[0, 1]$ after noise. The fixed-pathway variant duplicates context into both cue branches; the learned-routing variant requires the router to discover cue separation from data. This feedback-rank diagnostic tests structured pathway-vector broadcast inside the nonnegative-input regime.

D.3 Depth Scaling and Noise Robustness

These stress diagnostics keep the same broad model family while changing dendritic depth or corrupting the broadcast signal. For depth scaling, dendritic depth varies from 1–4 layers (branch factors $[9]$ to $[3, 3, 3, 3]$): shunting local degrades from 63.5% to 57.4%, additive local falls from 54.9% to 29.7%, the shunting advantage grows from +8.5 to +27.7 pp, and matched backpropagation references remain near 90–92% (Fig. S6A). For noise robustness, Gaussian noise $\mathcal{N}(0, \sigma^2)$ is added to the broadcast error; shunting remains robust to $\sigma \leq 0.1$ (about 62%), while additive drops from 46.5% to chance at $\sigma=1.0$, indicating that shunting credit signals carry useful learning information beyond broadcast magnitude alone (Fig. S6B).

NeurIPS Paper Checklist

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Question: Do the main claims made in the abstract and introduction accurately reflect the paper’s contributions and scope?

Answer: [\[Yes\]](#)

Justification: The abstract and introduction state the paper’s main mechanistic claim, the scope of the conductance-based setting, and the regime-dependent nature of the empirical results; see Sec. 1 and Sec. 5.

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